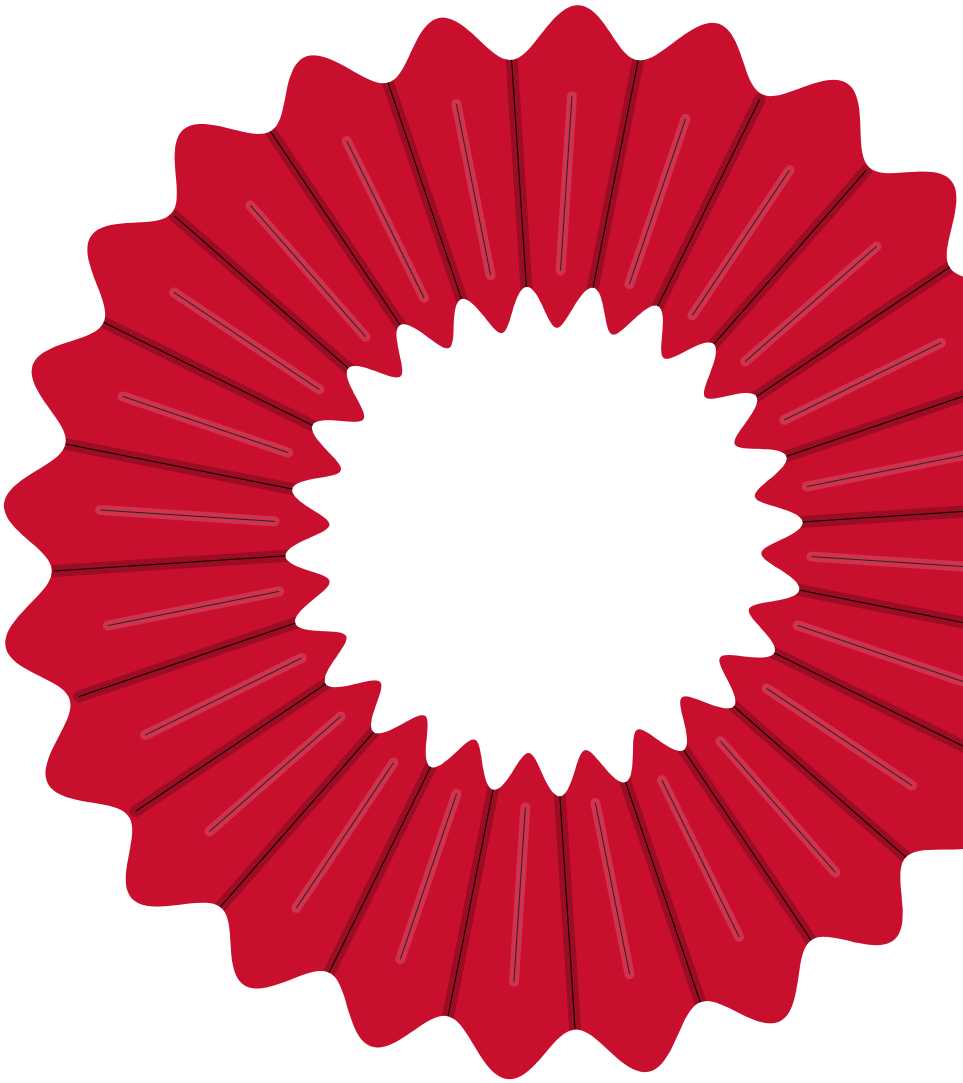


The Pharmacy of Westerburg

Sovereignty, Sacrifice, and the Making of an Antidotal Humanism in Michael Lehmann and Daniel Waters's Heathers *(1989)*

A dissertation
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Abstract

This dissertation contends that *Heathers* (dir. Michael Lehmann, scr. Daniel Waters, 1989) is not a satire of adolescence but a philosophical anatomy of the social bond as such, conducted under the sign of the *pharmakon*—the Greek term that designates, undecidably, poison and remedy, drug and charm, writing and pigment. Read through Plato's *Phaedrus* and Jacques Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy," Westerburg High School emerges as a pharmacy in the strict sense: a polity that regulates its internal violence through substances (drain cleaner, an emetic prank, the anaesthetic slush), writings (forged love letters, forged suicide notes, a diary, a petition), colours (the chromatic code of red, green, yellow, and blue), and commodities (the pop anthem "Teenage Suicide (Don't Do It)"), each of which cures by poisoning. The economy distributes three offices—*pharmakon*, *pharmakos* (scapegoat), and *pharmakeus* (poisoner, sorcerer, forger)—and obeys a Girardian law: a crisis of undifferentiation, figured by three girls bearing a single name, is resolved by victims whose murders are rewritten, through forgery, as consent, and whose deaths are thereby converted from crimes into sacraments.

The argument proceeds in nine chapters. A genealogy of the screenplay's sources (Kubrick, Salinger, Ray, Malick, Ashby, De Palma, Sherwood Anderson, Twain, Carroll) establishes the film as a determinate negation of the John Hughes cycle. The clique's political theology is reconstructed through Kantorowicz's doctrine of the king's two bodies, Schmitt's decisionism, Weber's routinization of charisma, and Freud's group psychology, with the red scrunchie read as regalia and as Butler's transferable phallus. The film's "suicide epidemic" is situated within the Durkheim–Tarde controversy, the Werther effect, and the clinical suicidology of the 1980s. J.D. is read through the Romantic-nihilist line that runs from Goethe's Mephistopheles and Wagner's *Liebestod* through Nietzsche, Dostoevsky, Camus, Bataille, and Benjamin's diagnosis of the aestheticization of politics; the therapeutic culture incarnated by Pauline Fleming is anatomized via Rieff, Lasch, Foucault, Heidegger, Adorno, Debord, Baudrillard, Dewey, Arendt, and Stiegler. Two comparative chapters follow. The first reconstitutes the film's feminist stakes through Beauvoir, Woolf, Gilbert and Gubar, Shirley Jackson, Muriel Spark, Kristeva, Mulvey, Silverman, Clover, Creed, Butler, Gilligan, Rich, Sedgwick, Carter, Lorde, and Haraway. The second places the film within the humanist and anti-humanist debates of its *annus mirabilis*, 1989—the year of Fukuyama's "The End of History?", Rorty's *Contingency, Irony, and Solidarity*, and Shklar's "The Liberalism of Fear"—drawing on Hegel, Kojève, La Boétie, Montaigne, Pico, Kant, Fromm, Levinas, Arendt, and Todorov.

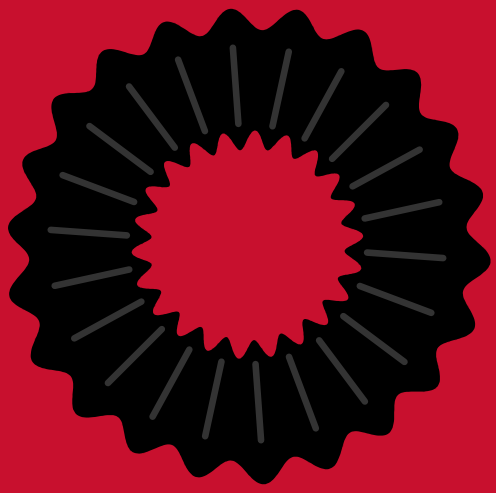
The dissertation's original contribution is a theory it names **antidotal humanism**. Joining Paracelsus's founding axiom of toxicology (*sola dosis facit venenum*) to Mauss's philology of the poisoned gift (*Gift*/gift) and to the etymology of the antidote as a thing "given against," it observes that the film is framed by two invitations addressed to the same outcast girl—a forged love letter that opens the narrative as humiliation, and a genuine invitation that closes it as hospitality—and argues that the second enacts neither cure nor counter-cure but a counter-gift: a measured, ironic, and non-innocent dose of recognition administered from the very position of sovereignty that the sacrificial economy produced. Formalized in five propositions, in a "sheriff's paradox," and in the figure of the "Veronican act" (after the saint who wiped the face of the condemned on the road to execution), antidotal humanism is proposed as a feminist *ethical posology*—a science of the dose of care—able to survive the critique of humanism without relapsing into sentimental reconciliation or apocalyptic purgation. The conclusion argues that the film, shadowed after Columbine and resurrected through home video, prescribes its own mode of reception, and is itself the antidote it describes.

Note on Citation and Method

Heathers is cited from its theatrical release (New World Pictures, 1989). Dialogue is quoted sparingly and in brief; longer exchanges are paraphrased, and scenes are identified by narrative position rather than timecode. Classical texts are cited by Stephanus (Plato) and Bekker (Aristotle) pagination, Nietzsche by work and section, Hegel's *Phenomenology* by paragraph, Heidegger's *Being and Time* by section, and Freud by *Standard Edition* volume. Dates in the running text are those of first publication; the translations used are listed in the Works Cited.

Three interpretive registers are braided throughout. The first is *philosophical genealogy*: the reconstruction of the conceptual lineages—a few acknowledged by Waters, most not—that the film activates. The second is *comparative intertextuality*: the placing of the film beside feminist and humanist works with which it shares problems rather than sources. The third is a *close reading* attentive to onomastics, chromatics, and props, which treats names, colours, and objects (the cup, the note, the bullet, the scrunchie) as condensed arguments. Claims about authorial intention are confined to what Waters and Lehmann have publicly recounted; every other connection is asserted at the level of structure, not influence.

The method as a whole may be called a *pharmacological hermeneutics*. It asks of every element in the film not only what it means but what it does to the body politic that ingests it, and in what dose. The same posology governs the dissertation's own handling of harm. Killings, sexual coercion, and suicide attempts are named plainly, together with those who committed them; the specific mechanics of suicide are named only where the argument depends on them, in keeping with the media guidance the dissertation itself examines (Centers for Disease Control 1988; World Health Organization 2000).



Introduction

Teen Angst with a Body Count

I.1 The Problem: From Angst to Arithmetic

Midway through *Heathers*, Veronica Sawyer, monocle fixed, informs her diary that her "teen angst bullshit" now "has a body count." The line is at once the film's self-description and its scandal. It converts the most privatized affect of late-twentieth-century American culture—adolescent *Angst*, the genre-defining emotion of the teen film—into a public quantity, a tally. Where the dominant teen cinema of the 1980s treated angst as a symptom awaiting therapeutic resolution (a detention survived, a prom attended, a misunderstanding dissolved in a freeze-frame), *Heathers* treats it as a political force that produces corpses, institutions, rituals, and myths. Angst becomes arithmetic; the bedroom diary becomes the ledger of a polis.

This shift of register licenses the claim that organizes what follows. *Heathers* is a work of social philosophy in the costume of black comedy, and its object is not adolescence but the social bond observed at the moment of its constitution. Adolescence is the film's laboratory rather than its subject, because the American high school supplies what political philosophy has always had to imagine: a state of nature with a curriculum, a polity refounded every autumn, in which sovereignty, law, sacrifice, and myth must be produced from scratch by subjects not yet fully interpellated by adult institutions. J.D.'s most consequential proposition, delivered at the climax, makes the point explicit: posterity, he predicts, will judge that the school destroyed itself not because society neglected it but because the school *was* society. The film takes this proposition with complete seriousness—and then refuses its conclusion.

The question the film poses is a displacement of the one Albert Camus called the only truly serious philosophical problem. Camus asked whether life is worth living (1942). *Heathers* asks who is authorized to declare, in writing, that a life was not worth living—and what a community becomes when it accepts such writing as true. Its central device, the forged suicide note, relocates the problem of suicide from the interior of the subject to the exterior of the social text. A death is ruled voluntary by a signature; a murder is converted into a confession; a tyrant becomes a martyr; and a school that had no community acquires one in mourning. The film is thus an inquiry into the conditions under which the social bond requires a victim, and requires the victim to have consented.

I.2 Corpus and Context

Directed by Michael Lehmann from Daniel Waters's first produced screenplay, produced by Denise Di Novi for New World Pictures, and released in the United States in the spring of 1989, *Heathers* failed commercially and survived as a cult object through home video, repertory screening, and the citational economy of later teen cinema. Its afterlife has been pharmacological in precisely the sense developed here. On 20 April 1999 two students at Columbine High School in Littleton, Colorado, Eric Harris and Dylan Klebold, shot and killed twelve students and a teacher before killing themselves;

they had also planted bombs in the school cafeteria, which failed to detonate. The film was reread in that light as prophecy and as provocation, since its climax is a student's plan to bomb his school during an assembly, and since early press coverage, later largely discredited (Cullen 2009), tied the killers to a "Trench Coat Mafia" clique whose dress recalled J.D.'s. The stage musical by Laurence O'Keefe and Kevin Murphy (2014) recomposed the film as a romance with a redemptive arc; a television adaptation was postponed in 2018 after a nineteen-year-old former student, Nikolas Cruz, shot and killed fourteen students and three staff members at Marjory Stoneman Douglas High School in Parkland, Florida, on 14 February of that year; and its genome passed, in attenuated and therapeutic form, into *Mean Girls* (2004), directed by Waters's brother Mark Waters. A film about the contagious power of representation has itself been treated, at intervals, as a contagion.

Scholarship has largely accommodated *Heathers* within the historiography of the teen film (Lewis 1992; Shary 2002; Driscoll 2011), where it figures as the genre's satirical limit-case, and within the cultural history of the "mean girl" discourse that crystallized after 2002. Both accommodations are accurate and insufficient. The first reads the film's philosophy as parody; the second reads its politics as psychology. Neither registers the systematic character of the film's thought: the rigor with which it links poison to writing, writing to sacrifice, sacrifice to sovereignty, and sovereignty to care. That systematicity is not imposed by theory but discovered in the film, which stages its arguments in condensed objects—a cup, a note, a bullet, a scrunchie—whose semantic charge vastly exceeds their narrative function.

I.3 Thesis

The dissertation advances three claims and derives from them one theory.

First, Westerburg is a *pharmacy*. Following Plato's *Phaedrus* and Derrida's reading of it (1972), the film organizes its world around the *pharmakon*, the agent that is simultaneously remedy and poison, and around the two figures the Greek lexicon binds to it: the *pharmakeus* (poisoner, sorcerer, forger) and the *pharmakos* (the scapegoat expelled to purify the city). Veronica, a gifted forger of handwriting, is the film's *pharmakeus*; Heather Chandler, its first *pharmakos*; the forged suicide note, its master *pharmakon*.

Second, sovereignty in Westerburg has *two bodies*. The name "Heather" functions as a corporation sole in Ernst Kantorowicz's sense (1957): a body politic that survives the death of each natural body and is transmitted through a fetish—the red scrunchie—whose passage from Chandler to Duke to Veronica traces the history of a crown. The film's political theology is accordingly a theory of succession, and its climax is a coronation.

Third, the sacrificial economy has *no internal exit*. Every remedy proposed within it —J.D.'s apocalyptic purge, Pauline Fleming's therapeutic "healing," the sentimental reconciliation of social types that the John Hughes cycle had made generic—re-enters the economy as a further poison.

From these claims the dissertation derives a theory it calls *antidotal humanism*. The film is framed by two invitations addressed to Martha Dunnstock, the school's most abjected student: a forged love letter, written by Veronica at the Heathers' command, which opens the narrative as an instrument of humiliation; and a genuine invitation, issued by Veronica in the final scene, to spend prom night watching videos. Between the two, the *pharmakeus* passes through the entire pharmacy. The second invitation is not a cure. It is a counter-gift—an *antidoton*, literally a thing "given against"—administered in a deliberately minimal dose from the position of sovereignty Veronica has just seized. Antidotal humanism names the ethics of that gesture: a humanism that knows every remedy to be a poison, every gift to be potentially *Gift* (German: poison), and every sovereignty to rest on concealed violence, and which therefore stakes everything on *dose*—on measure, irony, and the care of a single face.

I.4 Method and Commitments

The method has been specified in the preceding note. Two commitments require statement. The first is a refusal of the opposition between philosophy and popular film. The dissertation treats *Heathers* as Stanley Cavell treated the Hollywood comedies of remarriage: as a site where philosophy is not illustrated but conducted (Cavell 1981). The second is a refusal of the opposition between feminism and humanism, which much late-twentieth-century theory staged as antagonism. The film's trajectory—from a girl who forges the voices of the dead to a girl who receives the face of the living—requires both vocabularies, and each corrects the other's characteristic failure: humanism's habit of universalizing a masculine subject, and a certain feminism's readiness to abandon the universal to those who abuse it.

I.5 Plan of the Work

Chapter One reconstructs the genealogy of screenplay and mise-en-scène, from the Kubrickian ambition Waters has repeatedly avowed to the toponymic and onomastic allusions—Sherwood Anderson, Twain, Salinger, James Dean, Lewis Carroll—that saturate the film, and reads the whole as a determinate negation of the Hughes cycle. Chapter Two develops the pharmacological reading through Plato, Derrida, Paul de Man, and the clinical history of the suicide note. Chapter Three reconstructs the clique's political theology. Chapter Four places the film's suicide wave within the sociology and epidemiology of imitation from Goethe to the Centers for Disease Control. Chapter Five reads J.D. as the terminus of a Romantic-nihilist tradition. Chapter Six

anatomizes the therapeutic *pharmakon*. Chapters Seven and Eight undertake the comparative work the film itself demands, in feminist and humanist registers respectively. Chapter Nine formalizes antidotal humanism, tests it against five objections, and specifies its limits. The Conclusion argues that *Heathers*, by ending with an invitation to watch videos, prescribed the conditions of its own survival.



Chapter One

Genealogies of Westerburg

Heathers *is a determinate negation of the 1980s teen film, assembled from the genre's own prehistory and from a literary tradition the genre had forgotten. This chapter reconstructs that genealogy in six movements: the Kubrickian ambition of the screenplay, its Salingerian and Deanian onomastics, its debts to the outlaw-couple and prom-apocalypse films, its toponymy, its opening emblem, and its insurgency against John Hughes.*

1.1 The Kubrickian Wager

Waters has repeatedly recounted that he wrote *Heathers* hoping Stanley Kubrick would direct it, on the reasoning that a filmmaker who had produced a definitive instance of nearly every genre—the war film, science fiction, horror, the costume drama—might complete the series with the teen film. The anecdote is usually told as comedy. It is better read as a statement of method, since Kubrick's work supplies three templates the screenplay transforms.

A Clockwork Orange (1971), after Anthony Burgess's novel of 1962, provides the model of an invented adolescent idiolect whose artificiality protects it from obsolescence and whose estrangement converts violence into style. Waters's coinages—"very" as a free-standing intensifier, "what's your damage," "greetings and salutations"—perform the same double operation, and Waters has described the invented slang as a hedge against dating. The same film supplies, in the Ludovico technique, a figure of therapy as violence: an aversive cure, administered by drug and image, that abolishes the capacity for moral choice it claims to restore. That figure returns, softened into sentimentality, in Pauline Fleming's healing workshop. *Dr. Strangelove* (1964) supplies the farce of apocalypse, the eroticized bomb, and the doomsday logic of a destruction that, once armed, cannot be recalled; J.D. strapping explosives to his own body at the climax rewrites Major Kong's descent astride the warhead as adolescent *Liebestod*. *Full Metal Jacket* (1987), Kubrick's most recent film when *Heathers* entered production, supplies the institution that manufactures its own killer: the barracks produces Private Pyle, who shoots his drill instructor and then himself, as the exact negative of its discipline, as Westerburg's hierarchy produces J.D.'s apocalypse, which ends in his own death, as the exact negative of its order. Pyle's murder-suicide is the template of J.D.'s arc.

1.2 Salinger, Dean, Ray

Jason Dean's initials and surname bind him to the two tutelary figures of postwar American adolescence. The initials evoke J. D. Salinger, whose *The Catcher in the Rye* (1951) gave the adolescent critique of the "phony" its canonical idiom and gave Holden Caulfield his one positive fantasy: to stand at the edge of a cliff and catch the children who run toward it. *Heathers* inverts the fantasy with precision. The character who bears Salinger's initials is the anti-catcher, the one who pushes; the catcher is Veronica, who bursts into the school lavatory to interrupt Heather McNamara's attempt on her own life.

The surname evokes James Dean and, through him, Nicholas Ray's *Rebel Without a Cause* (1955), whose architecture *Heathers* reproduces almost beam for beam. Ray's film contains a planetarium lecture on the end of the earth in fire and the insignificance of man before the cosmos, which J.D. converts into a program; a "chickie run," the game of death for recognition, which J.D. converts into a politics; a father whose

authority has collapsed into domestic farce (Jim Stark's father in an apron), which returns as Big Bud Dean's inverted greeting ritual, in which father and son exchange roles; and a sacrificial victim who dies at the planetarium in the final reel. That victim is named Plato. The pharmacological reading of the next chapter may therefore claim, without forcing, that *Heathers* descends from a film in which Plato is the scapegoat.

1.3 Couples, Corpses, Proms

Four further films complete the cinematic genealogy. Terrence Malick's *Badlands* (1973) supplies the couple: a young man styled after James Dean who kills with charismatic indifference, and a teenage girl whose affectless voice-over narrates the spree in the diction of a fan magazine. Veronica's diary narration descends from Holly's, with one decisive difference: Holly never judges, and Veronica cannot stop judging. Hal Ashby's *Harold and Maude* (1971) supplies the staged suicide as performance—Harold's elaborate fake deaths, mounted for an indifferent mother—which returns when Veronica stages her own hanging to deceive J.D.; Ashby's film also supplies the structure of rescue from a death-cult by an ethic of vitality, which *Heathers* rewrites as an ethic of care.

Tim Hunter's *River's Edge* (1986), loosely derived from the 1981 killing of fourteen-year-old Marcy Conrad in Milpitas, California, by a sixteen-year-old schoolmate, Anthony Jacques Broussard, who then showed her body to other teenagers, none of whom told the police for days, supplies the adolescent cohort that contemplates a classmate's corpse with anomic curiosity: the Hughes cycle's suppressed underside. The film's premise is the real case's most disturbing fact—not the killing alone but the witnesses' silence. Brian De Palma's *Carrie* (1976), after Stephen King's 1974 novel, supplies the prom as sacrificial altar, the clique of girls as the agent of humiliation, and the apocalyptic destruction of a school community by its most abjected member. Waters has described an early ending in which the school is destroyed and the dead reconvene at a prom in heaven; that ending would have consummated the *Carrie* lineage. The released film refuses it, and the refusal is the beginning of its ethics.

1.4 Toponymy and Onomastics

The film's names are condensed arguments. Westerburg High School is a widely reported homage to Paul Westerberg of the Replacements, whose "Bastards of Young" (1985) had turned a generation's abandonment by its elders into an anthem; the name also embeds the *Western* and the *burg*, the frontier town awaiting its sheriff, and so prepares the film's final line. The town, Sherwood, Ohio, conjures Sherwood Anderson's *Winesburg, Ohio* (1919), whose prefatory "Book of the Grotesque" sets out an old writer's theory: truths are beautiful until a person seizes one, calls it his own, and lives by it, at which moment he becomes a grotesque and his truth a falsehood. J.D. is

Anderson's grotesque. He has seized the truth that the school is society, and the truth has become lethal. Sherwood also answers Shermer, Illinois, the suburb in which Hughes set most of his films.

Veronica's forename descends, by a popular etymology the Middle Ages made doctrinal, from *vera icon*, "true image" (its philological source is the Greek *Berenike*, "bearer of victory"). Saint Veronica is the woman who, at the Sixth Station of the Cross, steps from the crowd to wipe the face of the condemned and receives his likeness on her veil. Her surname recalls Tom Sawyer, who attends his own funeral and relishes the eulogies (Twain 1876); Twain's satire of mourning sentimentality, extended in *Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* through Emmeline Grangerford's obituary verses, is the direct ancestor of the film's funeral comedy.

"Heather" names the heath (*Calluna vulgaris*), the plant of waste ground, and through "heathen" the dweller outside the baptized community; it was also among the most fashionable names given to American girls of the early-1970s birth cohort, and is therefore a mass-produced singularity. "Chandler" is the maker of candles, the one who gives light by consuming it; "Duke" is a sovereign title. "Jason" in 1989 meant Jason Voorhees of the *Friday the 13th* cycle, the serial killer of adolescents; it also recalls the Argonaut whose abandoned wife destroyed his new bride with a poisoned robe. "Martha" names the sister of Lazarus (John 11) and the figure of unthanked service (Luke 10:38–42); "Dumptruck," her epithet, is a defacement.

Remington, the college whose party precipitates the first murder, bears the name of the arms manufacturer that mass-produced the first commercially successful typewriter—the conjunction of inscription and firearm that Friedrich Kittler analyzed as the militarization of writing (Kittler 1986), and the conjunction that drives the plot. Even the surname of the therapist-teacher, Fleming, is that of the discoverer of penicillin, the century's emblematic remedy, whose overuse breeds resistance. The pharmacological reading cannot resist the accident. Table 1 consolidates these correspondences.

Table 1. Figures, emblems, names, and offices

Figure	Emblem	Onomastic resonance	Office in the pharmacy	Principal lenses
Veronica Sawyer	Blue; monocle and diary	*vera icon*; Tom Sawyer	*pharmakeus* (forger) turned bearer of the true image	Derrida, de Man, Beauvoir, Levinas, Gilligan
Heather Chandler	Red; scrunchie; croquet mallet	heath/heathen; candle-maker	sovereign and first *pharmakos*	Kantorowicz, Schmitt, Girard, Carroll
Heather Duke	Green; the inherited scrunchie	ducal title	successor; routinized charisma	Weber, Girard, Simmel

Figure	Emblem	Onomastic resonance	Office in the pharmacy	Principal lenses
Heather McNamara	Yellow; the radio confession	the least allegorized name	the panicking member	Freud, Durkheim, Foucault
Jason "J.D." Dean	Black duster; slush; bomb	Salinger; James Dean; Jason Voorhees	supplier of poisons; apocalyptic purger	Goethe, Nietzsche, Dostoevsky, Camus, Benjamin
Martha Dunnstock	Forged love letter; final invitation	sister of Lazarus; "Dumptruck"	the expelled; recipient of the counter-gift	Girard, Mauss, Levinas
Pauline Fleming	Healing workshop	discoverer of penicillin	therapeutic pharmacist	Rieff, Lasch, Foucault, Stiegler
Big Bud Dean	Demolition firm	the father as "buddy"	collapsed paternal law	Freud, Lacan

1.5 The Croquet Lawn and the Queen of Hearts

The croquet tableau that opens the film is its first theorem. Croquet is the lawn game whose central gesture is the expulsion of another player: having struck an opponent's ball, the player may take a "croquet stroke" that drives it away across the lawn. The scapegoat mechanism is rendered as Victorian leisure, and Lehmann's frontal compositions, saturated primaries, and deadpan tempo give the sequence the legibility of an emblem book.

The intertext is Lewis Carroll's *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* (1865), in which the Queen of Hearts plays croquet with flamingos for mallets and hedgehogs for balls and punctuates the game with sentences of decapitation. Heather Chandler, in red, is Carroll's Queen: a sovereign whose rules are arbitrary, whose game is the management of expulsion, and whose justification for cruelty, when asked, is the tautology of power itself—"Because I can be." Carroll's chapter opens, moreover, with gardeners painting white roses red to conceal an error from the Queen. The first act performed on her croquet ground is thus a forgery in pigment undertaken to escape sovereign violence: an exact emblem of the economy Chapter Two will name.

1.6 The Anti-Hughes Insurgency

Against these sources stands the hegemonic text the screenplay was written to negate. Hughes's *The Breakfast Club* (1985) confines five types—the brain, the athlete, the basket case, the princess, the criminal—to a Saturday detention and dissolves their differences in confession. Two features of its reconciliation matter here. It is pharmacologically induced: the communion is catalyzed by shared marijuana, so that Hughes's humanism of types is, quite literally, a drug-assisted therapy. And it is sealed by a letter,

read in voice-over, informing the vice-principal that each of them is all of the types at once—a humanist universal composed, like every letter in *Heathers*, for an adult reader.

Heathers answers both features. Its drugs kill; its letters forge; and J.D. states the negation outright when he tells Veronica that the only place where different social types can genuinely get along is heaven. The released ending refuses Hughes's communion and J.D.'s heaven alike. The procedure is what Guy Debord and Gil J. Wolman called *détournement* (1956): the appropriation of the dominant form's elements and their turning against the order that produced them.

The ambition is legible across Waters's career. In *Batman Returns* (1992), which he wrote, Selina Kyle is pushed from an office window by her employer and returns from death as Catwoman. The woman who passes through death and returns sovereign is Waters's signature figure, and Veronica—who stages her own hanging and who, told after the final explosion that she looks like hell, replies that she has just got back—is its first incarnation.

2

Chapter Two

The Pharmacy of Westerburg

Westerburg is organized around the pharmakon*, and the film's three offices—poison, scapegoat, forger—are those that Plato's lexicon binds together and that Derrida's reading of the* Phaedrus *made explicit. This chapter reconstructs the pharmacy through five Platonic scenes and their cinematic inversions.*

2.1 Theuth's Gift

In the myth Socrates recounts near the close of the *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), the Egyptian god Theuth presents his inventions to King Thamus and commends writing as a *pharmakon* for memory and wisdom. Thamus rejects the gift: writing will implant forgetfulness in the souls of those who learn it, offering not memory but reminder, not wisdom but its semblance. Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968; collected 1972) demonstrated that the dialogue cannot stabilize the word on which its argument turns. *Pharmakon* means remedy and poison at once, and also drug, philter, charm, spell, dye, and paint. Every translation that resolves the ambiguity—"remedy" in Theuth's mouth, "poison" in Thamus's—commits the violence the dialogue thematizes, since it decides what the text holds undecidable.

Derrida traces the word's semantic chain to two cognates Plato does not use but that the language holds in reserve: *pharmakeus*, the sorcerer or poisoner, an epithet hurled at Socrates; and *pharmakos*, the human scapegoat expelled—in some accounts put to death—at the Athenian festival of the Thargelia to purify the city. He notes, after Diogenes Laertius, that Socrates was born on the sixth of Thargelion, the day on which the city purified itself.

Heathers reconstitutes this chain as narrative. Its substances, writings, and colours are *pharmaka*. Veronica, whose talent for forging handwriting makes her indispensable to the Heathers, is its *pharmakeus*. Its victims are *pharmakoi*, whose expulsion purifies the community and whose deaths, ritualized in assemblies and funerals, inaugurate a new civic piety. The chain is not a metaphor imposed on the film; it is the film's plot.

2.2 The Undecidable Cup

The first murder is a scene of literal pharmacy. On the morning after the Remington party—at which Veronica vomits, defies Heather Chandler, and is promised social annihilation on Monday—Veronica and J.D. enter Chandler's kitchen with a plan to humiliate her: a prank concoction of milk and orange juice intended to make her sick. J.D. pours drain cleaner into a second cup, ostensibly in jest; the cups are confused; Chandler drinks, and crashes through a glass table. The film distributes culpability with deliberate imprecision between J.D.'s intention and Veronica's inattention, and the imprecision is the point. Two *pharmaka* stand side by side—an emetic, which classical medicine counted among the purgative remedies, and a corrosive, which kills—and they are distinguished only by the hand that chooses. The kitchen enacts Derrida's undecidability as a choice between cups.

The emetic deserves emphasis. Veronica's prank aims at *katharsis* in its medical sense, the purgation Aristotle borrowed from Hippocratic medicine to name tragedy's effect on pity and fear (*Poetics* 1449b). The film is saturated with purgation: Veronica's vomiting at Remington, which expels her from the clique and from the college men's

predation; Heather Duke's bulimia, dismissed by Chandler as "so '87," which converts a pathology of self-purgation into a fashion with a vintage; Chandler's poisoning, a purge that kills; and J.D.'s final project, the purgation of the entire school by fire. *Heathers* is organized by a cathartic economy in which the social body repeatedly attempts to expel what it cannot digest. The emetic prank is that economy's ordinary, juvenile form; J.D.'s substitution of corrosive for emetic reveals its terminal form. The two cups are the two ends of catharsis: humiliation and annihilation.

2.3 The Socratic Cup Inverted

Philosophy, too, begins with a cup. The *Phaedo* closes with Socrates drinking the hemlock prescribed by the Athenian court (117a–118a), and its argument opens with Socrates' prohibition of suicide: human beings stand at a kind of guard post (*phroura*) which they may not abandon without divine summons (62b). Yet the same dialogue defines philosophy as the practice of dying (64a), and Plato's narration transforms a state execution into a voluntary death, an act of philosophical freedom. The meaning of Socrates' death is, in this precise sense, *written*: it is the work of Plato, who was absent from the death chamber (59b) and authored its significance.

Heathers inverts the Socratic scene term by term. Socrates' death is an execution that writing renders voluntary; Chandler's is a murder that writing renders voluntary. Socrates is a philosopher who chose his death; Chandler is a tyrant who chose nothing. Plato forges the philosopher's freedom; Veronica forges the tyrant's interiority. And as Plato's narrative helped found a school—the Academy, a community constituted around the memory of a sacrificed man—Veronica's forgery founds a cult: Westerburg constitutes itself, for the first time, as a mourning community around the memory of a sacrificed girl. The homology suggests that the founding of communities by the writing of a death is not an aberration of adolescence but a procedure as old as philosophy.

2.4 The Forged Note: Sincerity, Prosopopoeia, Iterability

The suicide note is the genre of sincerity par excellence: its authority rests on the presumption that a person about to die has no motive to lie. Lionel Trilling distinguished sincerity, the congruence between avowal and actual feeling, from authenticity, a more strenuous ideal that licenses transgression in the name of the true self (Trilling 1972). The forged note is a counterfeit of sincerity in the service of a crime that J.D. would justify in the language of authenticity. Its content—Chandler's posthumous confession that people assume beauty and popularity make life easy, and that no one understands she has feelings too—supplies the dead girl with precisely the depth she never displayed, and the school believes it because it wishes to.

The forgery problem stands, remarkably, at the origin of clinical suicidology. Edwin Shneidman and Norman Farberow's *Clues to Suicide* (1957) built its analysis on a comparison of genuine suicide notes with notes simulated by non-suicidal subjects, in order to learn what distinguishes the real from the counterfeit. The discipline that would later name itself suicidology began, then, by confronting Veronica's question: whether a suicide note can be forged, and how one would know. *Heathers* answers that the community does not want to know, because the forged note performs a social function the genuine one cannot. It absolves everyone.

Two theoretical frames sharpen the point. Paul de Man's "Autobiography as De-facement" (1979) analyzes prosopopoeia, the figure that confers a voice and a face on the dead, as the master trope of the epitaph, and argues that it deprives and disfigures to the very extent that it restores. The forged note is prosopopoeia in its purest form, and its author is the girl whose name means "true image." Veronica's first crime against the dead is a defacement in de Man's exact sense: she gives Chandler a face that is not hers. Derrida's "Signature Event Context" (1972) argues that a signature, to function at all, must be iterable—repeatable beyond its singular occasion—and that iterability makes forgery a structural possibility of every signature rather than an accident befalling some. Veronica's skill is therefore not a moral anomaly but the actualization of a possibility latent in all writing. The film's first forgery, a love letter in Kurt Kelly's hand that lures Martha Dunnstock into public humiliation, establishes the procedure; the suicide notes merely raise its stakes from humiliation to death.

2.5 Gyges, Thrasymachus, and the Noble Lie

Three further Platonic passages complete the pharmacy. In Book II of the *Republic*, Glaucon recounts the myth of Gyges' ring, which renders its wearer invisible, and argues that anyone so concealed would act unjustly, since justice is observed only from fear of detection (359c–360d). The forged note is a ring of Gyges: it renders the killers invisible inside their crime. The experiment Glaucon proposes as a thought exercise, *Heathers* performs as plot, and its result vindicates Glaucon's cynicism for exactly as long as the ring is worn.

In Book I, Thrasymachus defines justice as the advantage of the stronger (338c), and in the *Gorgias* Callicles argues that nature itself shows it right for the better to have more than the worse (483a–484c). Chandler's tautology—"Because I can be"—is Thrasymachus reduced to his performative core: power as its own justification, needing no theory because it acknowledges no audience it must persuade.

Most consequential is the noble lie of Book III (414b–415d): the myth of metals, by which citizens are to be persuaded that their stations were assigned by the earth itself, a falsehood that secures civic concord. The forged suicide notes are Westerburg's noble lies. They produce what no truth could: a school united in grief, convened in assem-

blies, reconciled across castes, solemnly attentive to its own fragility. Plato's paradox—that the just city must be founded on a lie—is restaged as a high-school paradox: the caring community is founded on forgery.

2.6 "Ich lüge": The Bullet That Tells the Truth

For the murders of Kurt Kelly and Ram Sweeney, J.D. supplies bullets he calls "Ich lüge" rounds, assuring Veronica that they merely tranquilize. The German means "I lie." The bullet confesses its own falsehood in a language its victims cannot read, and so instantiates the liar's paradox—ascribed to Epimenides, formalized by Eubulides—as ballistics: a statement true only if false. Lacan's treatment of the paradox in his eleventh seminar turns on the split between the subject of the enunciation and the subject of the statement. The "Ich lüge" round stages that split as a crime: the speaking subject tells the truth by means of a statement whose manifest content, a harmless tranquilizer, is false. It is the perfect emblem of the *pharmakon*—a remedy, so named, that is a poison, so stamped.

2.7 Pharmakon as Pigment

Pharmakon also meant dye, paint, and cosmetic, and Derrida dwells on the *Phaedrus*'s comparison of writing to painting, whose offspring stand as if alive but keep a solemn silence when questioned (275d). The Heathers' chromatic code—red, green, yellow, with Veronica in blue—is the film's cosmetic *pharmakon*: a system of signs worn on the body that cures the anxiety of indistinction by inflicting the violence of classification.

Goethe's *Theory of Colours* (1810), whose sixth part treats the "sensible-moral" effects of colour, supplies a key. Goethe attributes to pure red an impression of gravity and dignity, the colour of majesty; he observes that yellow, nearest the light and the most cheerful of hues, turns disagreeable at the slightest contamination; and he says that we love to contemplate blue not because it advances toward us but because it draws us after it. Read through Goethe, the code sorts the Heathers into sovereignty (Chandler's red), envy (Duke's green, Shakespeare's "green-eyed monster"), and a brightness easily sullied (McNamara's yellow), and assigns Veronica the colour of withdrawal—the colour of the one who will refuse. Duke's succession is accordingly chromatic as well as political: her accession is marked by the passage of red into her possession.

2.8 Conclusion: Three Offices

Westerburg is a pharmacy in the strict sense: a polity that regulates its violence through agents whose curative and toxic valences cannot be separated. Its offices are three. The *pharmakon* is whatever circulates—drink, note, bullet, colour, song. The *pharmakeus* is whoever prepares and administers it—Veronica the forger, J.D. the

chemist of demolition. The *pharmakos* is whoever is consumed by it—Chandler, Kurt, Ram, and, by contagion, the living who imitate them. What remains to be explained is why the community requires *pharmakoi* at all, and how sovereignty survives their deaths. Those questions belong to political theology.



Chapter Three

Heather's Two Bodies

Sovereignty in Westerburg is corporate, theological, and transmissible: "Heather" is an office that outlives its occupants, and the red scrunchie is its crown. This chapter reconstructs the clique's political theology through Nicene trinitarianism, Kantorowicz, Schmitt, Weber, and Freud, and closes with the scrunchie itself.

3.1 One Name in Three Persons

The film's foundational joke—three girls who share a first name—is a theological proposition. Nicene Christianity confessed one divine substance (*ousia*) in three persons (*hypostaseis*), and the Heathers are one name in three bodies: a single essence, "Heather," instantiated in persons distinguished by colour, temperament, and rank. The parody is exact in its asymmetries. Chandler is the unbegotten principle from which authority derives; Duke is the begotten, the one who imitates and will inherit; McNamara is the procession of spirit, the most diffuse and impressionable.

Augustine's *De Trinitate* sought analogies of the Trinity in the human mind—memory, understanding, will. Westerburg locates its trinity in the social mind, where the name confers identity and the person confers almost nothing. Veronica, outside the name, is the excluded fourth: the term the structure cannot accommodate, whose eventual accession must transform the structure itself.

3.2 Dignitas Non Moritur

Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) reconstructed the late-medieval and Tudor legal fiction by which the monarch possessed a mortal body natural and an immortal body politic. When the natural body died, the body politic passed instantaneously to the successor—*le roi est mort, vive le roi*—because, in the maxim the jurists adapted from canon law, the dignity never dies (*dignitas non moritur*). Ralph Giesey's study of the Renaissance French royal funeral (1960) documented the ceremonial consequence: a lifelike effigy of the dead king, displayed in state, received honours while the corpse lay hidden in its coffin, so that the body politic could be seen to persist.

Chandler's death obeys this jurisprudence with legal precision. Her natural body dies; "Heather" does not. Duke assumes the vacancy at once—adopting Chandler's manner, her ascendancy, her red, and above all her scrunchie—so that no interregnum occurs. The funeral, meanwhile, displays an effigy: not the dead girl, whose cruelty everyone remembers, but the fictive Heather of the forged note, the misunderstood and sensitive soul whose image receives the school's homage. The corpse, which is the tyrant, is hidden; the effigy, which is the martyr, is exalted. Giesey's funeral is restaged in a suburban church, and the forged note is the wax.

3.3 "Because I Can Be": Decision Without Norm

Carl Schmitt opened *Political Theology* (1922) with the definition that made him notorious: sovereign is he who decides on the exception. Sovereignty, on this account, is not the application of a norm but the decision that suspends norms, and it manifests itself most purely where it cannot be derived from any rule. Chandler's answer to the question of why she is so cruel—"Because I can be"—is decisionism in its purest civil form: an act of will that refers to nothing beyond itself.

Machiavelli's counsel that it is safer for a prince to be feared than loved, if one cannot be both (*The Prince*, ch. 17), describes her technique; Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) describes its field. The cafeteria is a war of all against all (ch. 13), pacified by an artificial person whose authority all have tacitly authorized. The frontispiece of *Leviathan*, a sovereign whose body is composed of the bodies of his subjects, is the visual formula for the clique: a single head, "Heather," composed of the deference of hundreds.

3.4 Charisma and Its Routinization

Max Weber distinguished charismatic authority, grounded in devotion to the extraordinary qualities of a person, from traditional and legal-rational authority, and identified the charismatic order's characteristic crisis as succession. Charisma is personal and therefore unstable; upon the leader's death it must either dissipate or be routinized (*Veralltäglichung*) into hereditary, official, or procedural forms (*Economy and Society*, 1922).

Duke's reign is charisma routinized. She does not possess Chandler's aura; she possesses Chandler's props. Her authority rests on the imitation of the predecessor's rituals and on custody of the predecessor's regalia, which is to say on the conversion of personal charisma into an inheritable office. The film registers the cost comically: Duke's tyranny is more anxious, more derivative, more dependent on display. Veronica's final self-designation as a "sheriff" names the next stage in Weber's sequence—legal-rational authority, the officer of a law rather than the bearer of a grace—and Chapter Nine argues that this terminological shift carries the film's political wager.

3.5 The Artificial Group: Freud's Church and Army

Freud's *Group Psychology and the Analysis of the Ego* (1921) analyzed two "artificial groups," the Church and the army, held together by a double libidinal tie: each member is bound to the leader, who occupies the place of the ego ideal, and through that common identification each is bound to the others. Freud's example of what follows the leader's loss is drawn from Nestroy's parody of Hebbel's *Judith and Holofernes*: a soldier cries that the general has lost his head, and the Assyrian army flees in panic. The group, deprived of its ego ideal, disintegrates into anxious individuals.

The Heathers form an artificial group of exactly Freud's type, and Chandler's death produces exactly Freud's panic—deferred, displaced, and concentrated in Heather McNamara, the member least able to substitute a new ideal for the lost one. Her radio confession and her attempt on her own life are the panic of a member whose ego ideal has been decapitated. Duke's accession is the counter-measure, the installation of a substitute ideal; but the substitute cannot fully re-bind the libidinal ties, and the

clique thereafter functions more like Freud's army than his Church, held together by discipline rather than love. The Judith example returns in Chapter Seven, where Veronica's killing of J.D. is read through Artemisia Gentileschi.

3.6 The Primal Horde and the Totem Meal

Totem and Taboo (1913) offered Freud's speculative myth of social origins: the sons of the primal horde kill the despotic father who monopolizes the women, consume him in a cannibal feast, and, overtaken by ambivalence and remorse, institute the prohibitions on murder and incest that found morality, religion, and law. The totem meal, repeated ritually, both commemorates and disguises the crime.

Heathers restages the myth with the sovereign's gender reversed. Chandler is the despot of the horde, monopolizing not women but recognition. Her murder is committed by a member of her court in alliance with an outsider; it is disguised by a myth, the forged note; and it is commemorated in rituals—funeral, assembly, workshop—that bind the survivors in a guilt most of them do not know they share. The order that emerges is not yet a law. It is a cult. The film's narrative work will consist in pushing the community from cult toward law, from the totem toward the sheriff.

3.7 The Scrunchie as Regalia and Transferable Phallus

The red scrunchie is the film's crown. It is worn by the sovereign, assumed by the successor, and finally taken by Veronica from Duke's head with the sentence that closes the political plot: "Heather, my love, there's a new sheriff in town." Its circulation traces the passage of the body politic as precisely as the coronation regalia Kantorowicz studied.

Lacan argued that the phallus is not an organ but a signifier—the signifier of desire as such, which functions only when veiled and which no subject simply possesses ("The Signification of the Phallus," 1958). Judith Butler's "The Lesbian Phallus and the Morphological Imaginary" (1993) radicalized the argument: if the phallus is a signifier, it is transferable, and its privileged attachment to the penis is a contingent ideological effect rather than a structural necessity. The scrunchie is a comic proof of Butler's thesis. It is a ring of gathered elastic fabric, morphologically the opposite of phallic, and yet it functions in the film's symbolic economy as the transferable signifier of power, passed among girls with no male mediation at all.

The ring-form invites two further comparisons. Plato's ring of Gyges confers invisibility; the scrunchie confers its opposite, total visibility, the power of being looked at. And in Wagner's *Ring* cycle the ring that grants mastery of the world is forged by Alberich at the price of renouncing love. The scrunchie, too, is held at the price of love —no Heather has a friend—and the final scene, in which Veronica seizes the ring and turns at once to an act of friendship, reverses Alberich's bargain.

William Golding's *Lord of the Flies* (1954) supplies the decisive contrast. Its conch, symbol of deliberative order among abandoned boys, is shattered at the moment of Piggy's murder, and with it the possibility of law. Waters's emblem of authority is not shattered but seized. The difference between the two fables of adolescent sovereignty—Golding's pessimism and Waters's ironic wager—lies entirely in that difference between destruction and appropriation.

3.8 Conclusion

The clique is a political theology in miniature: a trinity of persons in one name, a corporation sole whose dignity never dies, a decisionist sovereignty, a charisma routinized by succession, an artificial group bound by identification with its head, and a horde founded on the concealed murder of its despot. Its crown is a transferable phallus shaped like a ring. What political theology cannot explain is why the sovereign's murder, rather than producing anarchy, produces piety—why the school, having lost its tyrant, discovers itself united. That explanation requires the theory of mimetic violence.

4

Chapter Four

Contagion and Sacrifice

The school, having lost its tyrant, discovers itself united because Chandler's murder performs the function René Girard assigned to the founding sacrifice: it resolves a crisis of mimetic rivalry by concentrating diffuse violence on a single victim, who is then sacralized. This chapter reconstructs that mechanism and situates the film's "suicide epidemic" within the sociology and epidemiology of imitation from Goethe to the Centers for Disease Control.

4.1 Mimetic Desire and the Crisis of Distinctions

Girard's *Deceit, Desire and the Novel* (1961) argued that desire is not spontaneous but borrowed: we desire according to a model, a mediator whose desire designates the object. Where the mediator is socially distant (external mediation), imitation is reverent and harmless; where the mediator is near (internal mediation), the model becomes a rival, and imitation breeds hatred. Westerburg is a regime of internal mediation. Veronica desires what the Heathers desire—status, visibility, the power of designation—because the Heathers desire it, and she inhabits their world closely enough that the models are also obstacles. Duke's relation to Chandler is internal mediation in its purest form: she wants to *be* Chandler, and the wish is lethal to friendship before it is lethal to anyone's body.

Violence and the Sacred (1972) generalized the analysis to the social order. Archaic societies, Girard argued, are threatened above all by the erosion of differences; when distinctions collapse, rivalries multiply and the community dissolves into a war of doubles. Myth figures this "sacrificial crisis" through twins, plagues, and monstrous doubles. Three girls with one name are a sacrificial crisis in costume. The Heathers are differentiated from everyone else by their name and undifferentiated from one another by the same name, and the opening sequences show a hierarchy maintained only by continuous, ritualized cruelty—the expenditure of violence required to sustain distinctions that are, in essence, arbitrary.

4.2 The Founding Murder and the Double Transference

Girard's central hypothesis is that such crises are resolved spontaneously by the unanimous polarization of violence onto a single victim, whose death restores peace and whose figure is then sacralized. The victim undergoes a "double transference": blamed for the disorder while alive, credited with the order that follows its death. The scapegoat becomes a god.

Chandler's career after death is the double transference with documentary precision. In life she was the agent of the school's disorder; in death, recast by the forged note as misunderstood and suffering, she becomes the source of its new concord. Assemblies are held, grief is performed, rival castes discover a common feeling, and a dead tyrant becomes a saint. The pattern repeats with Kurt and Ram, whose murders are staged as a suicide pact between secret lovers. The planted evidence of their homosexuality—stereotyped bric-a-brac, among it a Joan Crawford postcard—inverts a stigma into a sacrament: two boys who had spread a false sexual rumor about Veronica after she rebuffed them become, in death, martyrs of an intolerance the community now ostentatiously renounces. One father's graveside cry—"I love my dead gay son!"—is the double transference spoken aloud. The victim, who would have been abjected in life for this trait, is adored in death for precisely the same trait.

4.3 Persecution Texts Inverted: The Perfect Crime

The Scapegoat (1982) identified the "stereotypes of persecution" by which texts written from the persecutors' perspective betray the mechanism they conceal: a crisis, an accusation of crimes that undermine differences, marks that single out the victim, and the violence itself. Persecution texts are legible, Girard argued, because they accuse; the accusation is the trace of the murder.

The forged suicide note is a persecution text of a higher order, because it does not accuse. It attributes the death to the victim's own will and thereby erases the persecutors from the scene. There is no crowd, no accusation, no executioner; there is only a sensitive soul who chose to leave. This is the perfect crime in the sense Jean Baudrillard gave the phrase (1995): a crime whose perfection consists in the disappearance of every trace of the crime. Where the archaic community remembered its victims as guilty, Westerburg remembers them as voluntary. The modern sacrificial text, the film proposes, is not the myth of the guilty victim but the myth of the consenting one. The proposition reaches beyond the film: every order that represents its casualties as having freely chosen their fate—in the labour market, in war, in the clinic—writes the same note.

4.4 Durkheim's Typology Distributed

Émile Durkheim's *Suicide* (1897) treated voluntary death as a social fact whose rates vary with two dimensions of collective life, integration and regulation. Insufficient integration yields egoistic suicide; excessive integration, altruistic suicide; insufficient regulation, anomic suicide; and excessive regulation—treated in a brief note to the chapter on anomie—fatalistic suicide, the death of persons whose futures are pitilessly blocked by oppressive discipline.

The film distributes Durkheim's typology across its deaths with suspicious completeness. Chandler's forged note narrates an *egoistic* suicide, the death of an individual insufficiently understood by the group. Kurt and Ram's fabricated pact narrates a *fatalistic* suicide, the death of those whose desire is crushed by social regulation. Heather McNamara's attempt is *anomic* in its precipitating cause, the collapse of the group's normative centre, and *fatalistic* in its texture, the suffocating discipline of the clique. Martha Dunnstock's attempt, imitative of the deaths that preceded it and plausibly of the attachment the forged love letter had exploited, is *anomic*: desire without limit or object. J.D.'s planned destruction of the school, sealed by a student petition he intends to present as a collective suicide note, is a parody of *altruistic* suicide—the dissolution of every individual into the collective, the death of all by the signature of all. The film does not illustrate Durkheim. It demonstrates that each of Durkheim's categories can be forged.

4.5 Tarde, Werther, and the Epidemiology of Imitation

Durkheim devoted a chapter of *Suicide* (Book I, ch. 4) to refuting the claim, associated with Gabriel Tarde's *The Laws of Imitation* (1890), that suicide spreads by imitation. Imitation may determine the form or timing of individual cases, Durkheim conceded, but it cannot explain social rates, which depend on the structural conditions of integration and regulation. *Heathers* stages the controversy and sides, at first, with Tarde: the deaths propagate through the school as a fashion, and the subsequent attempts follow the models the forged notes supplied.

The film's position is more radical than either. What spreads is the imitation of a forgery: a model that never existed. The literary original of this epidemiology is Goethe's *The Sorrows of Young Werther* (1774), whose hero's death was followed, by contemporary report, by imitative deaths and by bans of the novel in Leipzig and elsewhere. Two centuries later the sociologist David Phillips named the measurable rise in suicides following publicized ones the "Werther effect" (Phillips 1974). In 1986 the *New England Journal of Medicine* published two studies of adolescent suicides following news coverage and television films (Phillips and Carstensen 1986; Gould and Shaffer 1986). The Plano, Texas, cluster of 1983 and the joint suicide of four teenagers in Bergenfield, New Jersey, in March 1987 made "suicide cluster" a term of national journalism, and in 1988 the Centers for Disease Control issued recommendations for the prevention and containment of clusters, emphasizing community response and the conduct of the media.

Heathers was written and produced inside this discursive field, and its satire is aimed less at adolescents than at the apparatus that converted their deaths into narrative. It shows a community whose ostensibly preventive discourse—assemblies, workshops, songs, broadcasts—amplifies the phenomenon it treats. That is a pharmacological claim about prevention itself, and the film's later history shows the claim applying to the film (Chapter Nine, fifth objection).

4.6 The Precession of Simulacra and the Fashion of Death

Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981) described a regime in which the model precedes the real it was supposed to represent: the map engenders the territory. Westerburg's suicide wave is a precession of simulacra. The forged notes are copies without originals, since the deaths they describe never happened as described. Yet they generate real attempts, which then confirm the existence of the "epidemic" the forgeries invented. The simulation produces its own referent.

Georg Simmel's "Fashion" (1904) supplies the remaining mechanism. Fashion, Simmel argued, satisfies two contradictory needs at once—to imitate and to distinguish oneself—and its charm lies in its transience, in being at once beginning and end. Chandler's verdict on bulimia applies the logic of fashion to pathology, and the school applies it to death. Suicide becomes chic: a way of belonging to the moment by imitat-

ing the dead, and of distinguishing oneself by an act of apparent depth. Under the logic of fashion, death loses its singularity—the one property that, for Heidegger, made it the ground of authentic existence (Chapter Six).

4.7 Conclusion

The school is united by its victims because Girard's mechanism is operative: a crisis of distinctions, resolved by unanimous violence, sacralized by double transference. Westerburg's version, however, has two modern features absent from archaic myth. Its sacrificial texts represent the victims as consenting, which erases the persecutors and perfects the crime; and its sacred propagates by the imitation of simulacra, which makes it a fashion. The agent of both modernizations is the forger. The agent of the original violence, and of its final escalation, is J.D., to whom the argument now turns.

5

Chapter Five

The Spirit That Negates

J.D. is the terminus of a Romantic-nihilist tradition that runs from Goethe's Mephistopheles through Nietzsche, Dostoevsky, and Wagner to the surrealist and Futurist aestheticization of violence, and the film's achievement is to show that tradition's grandeur and its banality as a single phenomenon.

5.1 Mephistopheles in a Trench Coat

In Goethe's *Faust, Part One* (1808), Mephistopheles introduces himself as the spirit that always negates, and as part of that power which always wills evil and always works good. Both formulas describe J.D. His every act is a negation—of the clique, of the school, of the adult order, finally of himself—and his malignity produces, against its intention, the conditions of Veronica's ethical awakening and of the clique's collapse. The theodicy implied by Goethe's line is the film's ironic structure: evil is instrumentalized by an economy larger than itself.

The parallel extends to the plot. Faust supplies Gretchen with a sleeping draught for her mother so that the lovers may meet undisturbed; the mother dies of it, and Gretchen's ruin follows. Veronica, under J.D.'s aegis, serves Chandler—her social mother, the matriarch of her world—a cup prepared in his company, and Chandler dies of it. In both cases a young woman becomes the administering hand of a man's pharmacy, and the victim is a maternal authority. Goethe ends the first part with Gretchen condemned by Mephistopheles and saved by a voice from above, and the second with the Chorus Mysticus proclaiming that the Eternal Feminine draws us upward. Chapter Seven argues, with Beauvoir, that Veronica refuses both the condemnation and the salvation: she is neither the ruined girl nor the redemptive ideal, and she saves herself.

5.2 "Our Love Is God": Nietzsche and the Shadows of God

In *The Gay Science* §125 the madman announces that God is dead and that we have killed him, and asks what festivals of atonement, what sacred games, we shall now have to invent. Section 108 warns that, God being dead, his shadow may yet be shown in caves for thousands of years. J.D.'s declaration—"Our love is God"—is a shadow of God in exactly this sense: the post-theological re-sacralization of an immanent object, which Nietzsche diagnosed as nihilism's persistence rather than its overcoming. The line's continuation, an invitation to "get slushed," binds the theology of love to an anaesthetic, and so completes the diagnosis.

On the Genealogy of Morality (1887) distinguishes the noble mode of valuation, which affirms itself first and only afterward designates the low, from the slave revolt in morality, which begins by saying No to what is outside and derives its values from ressentiment (I §10). Chandler, absurdly, is Nietzsche's noble: her valuation begins in self-affirmation, and her cruelty is unreflective, a pathos of distance. J.D. is ressentiment disguised as active force. His rebellion is reactive in origin—a response to every school that has failed to receive him—and creative only in the sense in which a demolition is creative. The late notes collected as *The Will to Power* distinguish active nihilism, a sign of increased power that destroys what has lost its value, from passive nihilism, a sign of exhaustion (§22). J.D. performs the first while embodying the second;

his explosives are the instruments of a weary will dressed as a strong one. The suburban fathers around him—comfortable, routinized, blinking—are the "last men" of *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*'s prologue (§5), who have invented happiness and who blink.

5.3 Raskolnikov, Verkhovensky, Kirillov

Dostoevsky supplies three templates. Raskolnikov's article, discussed in Part III of *Crime and Punishment* (1866), divides humanity into ordinary people, who must obey, and extraordinary ones, who have the right to step over obstacles—even over blood—for the sake of an idea. J.D.'s self-understanding is Raskolnikovian, and his "Ich lüge" theory of permitted killing is Raskolnikov's article as practical joke.

Demons (1871–72) supplies two more. Pyotr Verkhovensky binds his revolutionary cell together by implicating its members in the murder of Shatov: complicity in blood is the cement of the group. J.D. binds Veronica the same way, and the film charts the precise degree to which shared guilt substitutes for love. Kirillov, who resolves to kill himself to prove that, without God, self-will is the highest attribute—to become the man-god—anticipates J.D.'s final act. J.D. dies by his own bomb outside the school he failed to destroy, and his death, like Kirillov's, is a demonstration staged for a single witness. Ivan Karamazov's formula, that without God everything is permitted, is the premise every J.D. requires. The film's ending supplies Alyosha's rejoinder—not as doctrine but as gesture.

5.4 Camus: Logical Crime and the Missing Limit

Camus's *The Rebel* (1951) opens by declaring the present an age of premeditation and the perfect crime, in which murder, no longer passionate, has acquired a philosophy. Its genealogy of metaphysical rebellion passes through Sade, the dandies, Ivan Karamazov, Nietzsche, and the surrealists, and one of its sharpest pages concerns André Breton's declaration in the *Second Manifesto of Surrealism* (1930) that the simplest surrealist act would consist in going into the street with a revolver and firing at random into the crowd. J.D.'s first appearance at Westerburg—firing blanks at Kurt and Ram in the cafeteria—is Breton's simplest surrealist act performed in a lunchroom. The blanks are the point: the act is theatrical, a gesture aimed at an audience. The narrative converts the blanks into live rounds, and in doing so traces Camus's argument that aesthetic rebellion, unchecked, becomes logical murder.

Camus's positive thesis is that authentic rebellion contains its own limit. The slave who says No to the master also says Yes to a frontier he will not let be crossed, and so affirms a value shared with all human beings: I rebel, therefore we exist. In *The Just Assassins* (1949), the revolutionary Kaliayev refuses to throw his bomb at the Grand Duke's carriage when he sees children inside it. The bomb has a limit; the rebellion has a measure (*la mesure*). J.D.'s bomb has none. It is meant for a pep rally—the entire

student body, children by any reasonable definition—and it is justified by the claim that the school is society. Veronica's intervention in the boiler room is Kaliayev's refusal enacted by a second person against the bomber, and her subsequent conduct is Camus's "thought of the meridian": a rebellion that knows where to stop.

5.5 Liebestod: De Rougemont, Wagner, Bataille, Heathcliff

Denis de Rougemont's *Love in the Western World* (1939) argued that the Western myth of passion, crystallized in the legend of Tristan and Iseult, is secretly in love not with the beloved but with obstruction and death. Its lovers are bound by a potion—a *pharmakon*—and their union is consummated only in the death Wagner would set to music as *Liebestod*. J.D.'s romance with Veronica follows de Rougemont's formula: it intensifies through obstacles, it is sealed by crime rather than intimacy, and it reaches its logical end in J.D.'s proposal that their love be consummated in the death of everyone. When Veronica refuses, J.D. chooses the Liebestod alone.

Georges Bataille's *Erotism* (1957) described eroticism as assent to life up to the point of death and bound it, through the concept of transgression, to sacrifice and the sacred. J.D. is an erotic theologian in Bataille's sense: he experiences murder as intimacy and the sacred as explosion. The literary lineage of this figure runs through Emily Brontë's Heathcliff (*Wuthering Heights*, 1847), whose very name is a heath and whose love is indistinguishable from destruction; through Kit Carruthers of *Badlands*; and, in 1989, through Jason Voorhees. The film's insight is that the Byronic lover and the slasher are one figure seen in different lighting.

5.6 Aesthetics and Anaesthetics

Walter Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technological reproducibility (1935–36) closes with a diagnosis of fascism: it aestheticizes politics, and humanity's self-alienation has reached the degree at which it can experience its own destruction as an aesthetic pleasure of the first order. Benjamin quotes Marinetti's manifesto on the Ethiopian war; Marinetti's founding Futurist manifesto (1909) had already glorified war as the world's only hygiene and demanded the destruction of museums, libraries, and academies. J.D.'s plan is the aestheticization of politics in suburban form. He wants the school's destruction to be seen; he prizes the extreme because, as he puts it, the extreme always seems to make an impression; and his model of social critique is spectacle. Marinetti's hygiene is purification—*katharsis*—and so the bomb is the cathartic economy's final term.

Susan Buck-Morss's rereading of Benjamin (1992) observed that modern aesthetics, originally a discourse of sensation, became a technique of anaesthesia: the numbing of a sensorium overwhelmed by shock. J.D.'s pharmacology runs along both axes. The

slush he recommends is an anaesthetic, a cold numbness that blots out pain; the bomb is an aesthetic, an overwhelming impression. Between anaesthesia and shock, the subject who might feel the suffering of others is never constituted.

The petition is the plan's political centrepiece. J.D. circulates it through the student body and intends to present it, after the explosion, as a collective suicide note. Rousseau's *Social Contract* (1762) grounded legitimate authority in the general will, constituted when each associate alienates himself wholly to the community; J.D.'s petition is a social contract in which each signatory alienates his life. It is the general will as death pact, and its form—a document signed by all in ignorance of its content—satirizes every consent that is extracted rather than given.

5.7 The Demolitionist's Son

J.D.'s home life is condensed in a single, devastating ritual. When J.D. greets his father, Big Bud Dean, the two exchange roles: the son speaks as the father and the father as the son. Lacan's account of psychosis turns on the foreclosure of the Name-of-the-Father, the signifier that installs symbolic law; where it fails, the father appears not as the bearer of a law but as an imaginary rival or double (*Seminar III*, 1955–56). The Deans' ritual stages that failure as domestic comedy. The paternal function has collapsed into a game of mirrors, and the only inheritance on offer is the father's trade, demolition. J.D. executes the paternal profession absolutely. He wishes to demolish the one institution in which, for once, he might have been recognized.

Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) proposed a drive that strives to restore an earlier state of things, the inorganic, and found its signature in the compulsion to repeat, exemplified by the child's game of *fort/da*, the mastery of absence by staged disappearance. The Dean household is organized around a maternal absence, and J.D.'s biography is a sequence of departures from school after school. The bomb is *fort/da* at the scale of an institution: the final disappearance by which the repeatedly displaced child displaces everything.

5.8 Conclusion

J.D. condenses the Romantic-nihilist tradition: Mephistophelean negation, Nietzschean shadow-theology, Raskolnikovian exceptionalism, Kirillovian suicide, surrealist gesture, Futurist hygiene, Wagnerian Liebestod, and a foreclosed paternal law. The film renders this tradition at once seductive and banal—Christian Slater's performance is the instrument of both—and so denies it the grandeur it claims. J.D. is Sherwood Anderson's grotesque: a man who seized a truth and became a falsehood. What he is not is an antidote. The next chapter shows that his antagonist, the therapeutic culture he despises, is no antidote either.

6

Chapter Six

The Therapeutic Pharmakon

The adult institutions of Westerburg answer the deaths with a therapeutic apparatus—workshops, assemblies, broadcasts, songs—that functions as a second pharmacy: its remedies are confessional, commodified, and spectacular, and each amplifies the contagion it claims to treat.

6.1 The Triumph of the Therapeutic

Philip Rieff's *The Triumph of the Therapeutic* (1966) diagnosed the replacement of "religious man," formed by communal commitments that bind and limit, by "psychological man," for whom the self's well-being is the final value and therapy the final institution. Christopher Lasch's *The Culture of Narcissism* (1979) extended the diagnosis to a society in which therapeutic sensibility had displaced politics and the pursuit of authenticity had become a technique of self-management. Pauline Fleming is the caricature both books might have commissioned: a counter-cultural teacher who converts grief into process, convenes a healing workshop in which students are urged to hold hands and share their feelings, and keeps one eye on the media throughout. Her therapy has no content beyond its own performance. It does not ask why students die; it asks that students feel together about dying.

Eva Illouz later described therapeutic discourse as a cultural matrix that requires suffering in order to supply its cure, and so tends to produce the pathologies it narrates (*Saving the Modern Soul*, 2008). Westerburg's therapeutic culture requires suicides in exactly this way. Its rituals presuppose that the dead chose their deaths—which is to say, they ratify the forgeries. Fleming is the forger's unwitting accomplice: her healing workshop is the institutional reception of the forged note. The therapeutic, like the sacrificial, needs consenting victims.

6.2 Confession on the Airwaves

Heather McNamara's call to a teen radio program, in which she confesses her own suicidal thoughts, is overheard by her schoolmates and becomes a source of public ridicule. The scene condenses Foucault's account of confession in *The History of Sexuality*, Volume 1 (1976): the West made confession one of its principal rituals for the production of truth, and the confessant, far from being liberated, is constituted by the power that solicits and authenticates the avowal. McNamara's confession is solicited by the culture's promise of help and delivered into a regime of visibility that converts it into humiliation. The radio is a confessional without a seal.

The same volume contains Foucault's most suggestive remark on suicide. In the age of biopower—a power that undertakes to administer life, to foster it or disallow it to the point of death—suicide became one of the first conducts to enter the field of sociological analysis, because it disclosed, at the borders and in the interstices of a power exercised over life, an individual and private right to die. *Heathers* adds a turn of the screw. Westerburg's forged suicides are not the interstices of biopower but its products: deaths inflicted by sovereign violence and then reinscribed, by writing, as exercises of the private right to die. In the film's school the old sovereign right to kill and the new biopolitical management of life meet in a single document.

6.3 Big Fun and the Culture Industry

The fictional band Big Fun's single "Teenage Suicide (Don't Do It)" climbs the charts as the deaths accumulate. The song is an artifact of what Horkheimer and Adorno called the culture industry (*Dialectic of Enlightenment*, 1944/1947): a standardized commodity that converts a social catastrophe into a consumable affect and sells its audience the feeling of moral seriousness. Its prohibition is indistinguishable from advertisement. The more the song is played, the more the act it forbids is glamorized; its anti-suicide message becomes the fad's anthem.

The satirical target is precise. The 1980s produced a moral panic, in Stanley Cohen's sense (1972), over popular music's alleged role in adolescent suicide: the parents of John McCollum, a nineteen-year-old who had taken his own life in 1984, sued Ozzy Osbourne and his record company, alleging that the song "Suicide Solution" had contributed to their son's death (the suit was dismissed), and the Parents Music Resource Center carried the question of lyrics to a Senate hearing in 1985. The panic assumed that the dangerous song was the transgressive one. *Heathers* inverts the assumption. The dangerous song is the didactic one, the commodity that offers itself as remedy: the culture industry's *pharmakon*.

6.4 The One Dies: Heidegger and Kierkegaard

Heidegger's *Being and Time* (1927) analyzed everyday existence as dominated by the anonymous "they" (*das Man*, §27), whose modes of disclosure are idle talk, curiosity, and ambiguity (§§35–37). Its treatment of death (§51) observes that the they acknowledges death only as an event that befalls "one"—*man stirbt*—and so tranquilizes Dasein about the mineness of its own death, converting a possibility that individualizes into a public occurrence. Westerburg's discourse about suicide is idle talk in the technical sense: endlessly circulated, never grasped. The fashion of death described in Chapter Four is the they's most refined tranquilization. By making death imitable, it makes it no one's own.

Kierkegaard's "The Present Age" (1846) had already diagnosed a society in which the press conjures "the public," a phantom without responsibility, and in which passionless reflection levels every distinction. The assemblies and broadcasts of *Heathers* are leveling machines: they make every death equivalent, every grief interchangeable, every student a member of a public that mourns without mourning anyone in particular.

6.5 The Abdication of the Adults

Hannah Arendt's "The Crisis in Education" (1958) argued that the emancipation of children from adult authority does not free them; it delivers them to the authority of the peer group, which is more tyrannical than any adult's, since the child inside it has

no recourse. Adults who refuse responsibility for the world into which they introduce the young, Arendt held, abandon them to that tyranny. *Heathers* is the cinematic demonstration of Arendt's essay. Its adults are absent (Big Bud), clichéd (Veronica's parents, whose conversation is a rotation of pleasantries), opportunistic (Fleming), bureaucratic (the principal), or sentimental (the fathers at the graveside). In their absence the Heathers' sovereignty is not an aberration but a structural necessity.

Arendt's critique was aimed at a pedagogical tradition indebted to John Dewey, whose *The School and Society* (1899) proposed that the school be an embryonic community life, a society in miniature. J.D.'s claim that the school *was* society is the Deweyan metaphor literalized and made lethal: if the school is society, then destroying the school is a political act, and the progressive metaphor becomes a terrorist premise. Louis Althusser's "Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses" (1970) identified the school as the dominant ideological apparatus of capitalist societies; Foucault's *Discipline and Punish* (1975) identified it as a laboratory of normalization whose characteristic instrument is the examination. J.D. attacks the apparatus; the Heathers administer its informal examination, the lunchroom poll; the adults preside, uncomprehending, over both.

Arendt's account of Eichmann's dependence on clichés and stock phrases, which she read as an inability to think from the standpoint of another (*Eichmann in Jerusalem*, 1963), illuminates the dinner-table scenes in the Sawyer household. Veronica's parents are not wicked; they are thoughtless, in Arendt's precise sense. Their clichés shield them from reality, and their daughter's crisis is invisible to them because it fits none of the available phrases. Kant defined enlightenment as the emergence from self-incurred immaturity and blamed the guardians (*Vormünder*) who keep the immature in tutelage (1784). In Westerburg the guardianship has been surrendered to the peer group, and the guardians are seventeen.

6.6 Stiegler: Taking Care

Bernard Stiegler's *Taking Care of Youth and the Generations* (2008) argued that the programming industries of television and marketing capture adolescent attention and short-circuit the intergenerational transmission through which a culture forms its young. *What Makes Life Worth Living: On Pharmacology* (2010) generalized the analysis: every technical support of attention is a *pharmakon*, capable of forming or destroying the capacity to care, and the task of a politics of mind is therapeutic in the original sense—*therapeia*, attendance, care—rather than curative. Stiegler's title restates Camus's question; his answer is a pharmacology.

The distinction between care and cure is the hinge of this dissertation. Westerburg's institutions offer cures: the apocalyptic purge, the healing workshop, the didactic song. None offers care, which would require sustained attention to a singular person over

time. Chapter Nine argues that the film's final gesture is the first act of care its world contains.

6.7 Conclusion

The therapeutic apparatus is a second pharmacy, homologous with the first. Its remedies—confession, commodity, spectacle, process—presuppose consenting victims and so ratify the forgeries; their effect is to amplify the contagion they claim to contain; and their agents are adults who have abdicated the responsibility Arendt assigned them. The pharmacy now has two wings, a sacrificial one staffed by adolescents and a therapeutic one staffed by adults, and neither contains an exit. The comparative chapters that follow ask where, outside both, the film's exit lies.

7

Chapter Seven

Girls as Pharmakoi

The pharmacy of Westerburg is gendered: its poisons pass through female bodies, its forgeries are written by a female hand, its sovereignty is held by girls, and its apocalypse is a man's. The feminist tradition supplies the instruments for reading this distribution, and the film, in turn, tests them.

7.1 The Gendered Distribution of the Pharmacy

Every principal female character passes through the pharmacy's body. Chandler drinks the drain cleaner J.D. poured and Veronica handed her; Duke purges; McNamara attempts suicide with pills in the school lavatory—the film's one literally pharmaceutical act—and is stopped by Veronica, who will later stage her own hanging. The male deaths come from outside the body: Kurt and Ram are shot in an ambush J.D. plans and Veronica joins, believing the rounds harmless, and J.D. dies by his own bomb. Within the clique, the female body ingests, expels, and is staged. Martha is the exception that defines the rule. Her suicide attempt, made in imitation of the suicides Veronica and J.D. had forged, injures her body from outside, as the boys' deaths do, and leaves her using a wheelchair. Excluded from the clique, she is excluded even from its poisons. The counter-gift of the final scene is accordingly addressed to the one girl the pharmacy never dosed and nonetheless harmed.

The historical imagination of poison as a feminine weapon, from Medea's robe to the Borgia legends and the Affair of the Poisons at the court of Louis XIV, is inverted: in Westerburg a man supplies the poison and a woman's hand administers it. The economy is not one in which women are naturally poisoners but one in which feminine labour—service, hospitality, the offering of a cup—is conscripted as the delivery mechanism of masculine violence.

7.2 Beauvoir: The Girl, the Myth, the Ambiguity

Simone de Beauvoir's *The Second Sex* (1949) declared that one is not born but becomes a woman, and its chapter on the girl described adolescence as the period in which the female subject learns to experience herself as an object for others' gaze, exchanging transcendence for the waiting that society calls femininity. The Heathers are that apprenticeship made sovereign: their power consists in being looked at, and their cruelty polices the conditions of visibility. Beauvoir's analysis of the myths of woman culminates in a critique of the "Eternal Feminine," Goethe's closing formula in *Faust*, which assigns woman the role of redemptive object rather than free subject. Veronica is the anti-Gretchen. She is neither the ruined girl condemned by the masculine pharmacy nor the ideal that redeems the man who ruined her; she redeems no one but herself, and only partially.

Beauvoir's *The Ethics of Ambiguity* (1947) supplies a typology of inauthenticity that maps the film's population with uncanny exactness. The "sub-man" flees freedom in apathy: Veronica's parents. The "serious man" subordinates freedom to values he takes as absolute and ready-made: the Heathers, the administrators, Father Ripper, all for whom status or propriety is simply given. The "nihilist" is, in Beauvoir's account, a disappointed serious man who turns his disappointment against the world and wills himself to be nothing: J.D. The "adventurer" pursues action for its own sake, indifferent to its ends: J.D. again, in his cafeteria mode. Against these, Beauvoir defines genuine

freedom as freedom that wills the freedom of others, since my freedom can be realized only in a world of free beings. Veronica's final invitation to Martha is the film's one act that wills another's freedom.

7.3 Woolf: Killing the Phantom, Keeping the Diary

Virginia Woolf's *A Room of One's Own* (1929) made the private room and the independent income the material conditions of women's writing. Veronica's room is where she writes, and her diary—kept with a monocle that parodies the masculine, Edwardian appurtenances of authorship—is the film's counter-archive to the forged notes. In "Professions for Women" (delivered 1931), Woolf described the first task of the woman writer as the killing of the "Angel in the House," the internalized phantom of self-sacrificing, sympathetic femininity that strangles candour. Veronica must kill two phantoms. The first is the feminine phantom of the clique, the Heather she might become; the second is the masculine phantom of the Romantic lover, the J.D. who would write her into his Liebestod. Woolf's metaphor of murder becomes literal in *Heathers*, and its cost is correspondingly literal.

Sylvia Plath is the tradition's other necessary witness, and the one the film's fashion of death most nearly parodies. *The Bell Jar* (1963) narrates a young woman's breakdown, her suicide attempt, and her passage through psychiatric institutions whose treatments—electroconvulsive therapy above all—appear first as punishment and later as relief: the therapeutic *pharmakon* exactly. "Lady Lazarus," written in 1962 and collected in *Ariel* (1965), stages its speaker's repeated survivals as a performance for a voyeuristic crowd that pays to look. Plath diagnoses the spectacle of a woman's self-destruction from inside the performer; *Heathers* diagnoses it from inside the audience, in a school that consumes its dead girls as content. Both locate the spectacle's violence in the gaze, and both refuse its consolations.

7.4 Voice and Gaze: Mulvey and Silverman

Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) argued that classical cinema organizes looking according to sexual difference: woman as image, man as bearer of the look. The croquet tableau parodies that economy—girls arranged as pictures on a lawn—and the Heathers have internalized the camera's regard as power. Kaja Silverman's *The Acoustic Mirror* (1988) extended the critique to sound, arguing that classical cinema withholds from women the disembodied, authoritative voice-over and confines the female voice to the body and its interiority. Veronica's diary narration breaches that rule. Her voice-over is not confession but judgment; it comments on the image rather than emanating from it. *Heathers* grants its heroine the narrative au-

thority Silverman showed classical cinema reserving for men—and makes that authority the instrument both of her crimes, since hers is the voice that forges, and of her redemption, since hers is the voice that refuses.

7.5 The Final Girl and the Monstrous-Feminine

Carol Clover's "Her Body, Himself" (1987), expanded as *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992), identified the slasher film's "Final Girl": boyish, watchful, sexually reticent, the one who survives to confront the killer. Veronica is a Final Girl with a twist Clover's corpus rarely contains: the killer is her lover and accomplice, and her confrontation with him is also a confrontation with her own complicity. The film's lexicon even anticipates Clover's title. Chandler's notorious exclamation, "Well, fuck me gently with a chainsaw," binds sexual violence, gendered tool, and comic hyperbole in a single line that reads, in retrospect, as a felicitous anachronism; and J.D.'s forename, in 1989, was the slasher's.

Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) read horror's female monsters, Carrie White preeminent among them, through Julia Kristeva's theory of abjection. Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) defined the abject as what the subject must expel to constitute its borders—vomit, waste, the corpse—and which threatens to return. *Heathers* is a film of the abject. Veronica's vomiting at Remington is the expulsion through which she separates from the clique; Duke's bulimia is abjection made routine and fashionable; Chandler's corpse in the shattered glass is the abject as spectacle, then concealed behind the effigy of the forged note. The film's satire of suburban propriety is, in Kristevan terms, the return of what propriety expels.

7.6 The Madman in the Boiler Room

Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) read Bertha Mason, Rochester's confined first wife in *Jane Eyre* (1847), as Jane's "truest and darkest double": the embodiment of the rage the heroine cannot avow. Bertha burns Thornfield and dies; Jane survives into a chastened marriage. *Heathers* reverses the genders and preserves the structure. J.D. is Veronica's dark double, the externalization of the angst her diary admits now has a body count, and he is housed not in an attic but in the boiler room, the basement turned furnace. He tries to burn the institution and dies by fire; Veronica survives into a chastened friendship. Gilbert and Gubar's thesis that the woman writer's rage is displaced onto a monstrous double is restaged with the double as a man—which suggests that the violence J.D. enacts is not his alone but a structural possibility of the heroine's own position.

7.7 Judith in the Boiler Room

Chapter Three noted Freud's use of Judith and Holofernes to illustrate panic upon the leader's loss. The Book of Judith narrates a widow who enters the tent of the Assyrian general besieging her city and beheads him, saving Bethulia; Artemisia Gentileschi's paintings of the scene (c. 1612–20) have become emblems of feminist art history, read in the light of what was done to the painter: in 1611 Agostino Tassi, a painter working with her father, raped her, and at his trial the following year she was made to repeat her testimony under torture by thumbscrews, as a test of its truth, while Tassi, though convicted, never served his sentence of banishment. Veronica's confrontation with J.D. in the boiler room restages Judith's in the tent. A woman who has been intimate with the besieger confronts him in his own quarters and wounds him to save the city. The film withholds Judith's triumph—J.D. completes his own death—but it preserves her act, and with it the iconography of a woman who ends a siege by violence directed at its single author rather than at the crowd.

7.8 Jackson and Spark: The Village, the Castle, the Set

Shirley Jackson's "The Lottery" (1948) depicts a small American town that stones one of its members to death in an annual ritual whose origin no one remembers; the victim is a woman, and the community's cohesion depends on the rite. Westerburg is Jackson's village with a curriculum. More pointedly, *We Have Always Lived in the Castle* (1962) is narrated by Merricat Blackwood, a young woman who poisoned most of her family with arsenic in the sugar bowl. After a fire, the townspeople who had always despised the Blackwoods ransack the house, and Merricat and her sister retreat into its ruins, a sanctuary of two women sealed against the world. *Heathers* answers Jackson point by point. Its poisoner is not the sanctuary's founder but its convert; its sanctuary is not a fortress against the town but an invitation extended into the town's lowest stratum; and it is founded on the renunciation of poison rather than its secret triumph.

Muriel Spark's *The Prime of Miss Jean Brodie* (1961) is the great novel of the girls' clique as political formation. Brodie's "set," each girl famous for a single attribute, is a charismatic sect whose teacher admires Mussolini and whose influence sends one pupil to her death on the road to the Spanish Civil War. It is betrayed by Sandy Stranger, who ends as a cloistered nun and the author of a treatise on psychology. Spark anatomizes the clique's charisma with a cold intelligence that *Heathers* shares. Veronica is Sandy: the most perceptive member, the one who betrays the sovereign, and the one whose betrayal is morally ambiguous because it is also an assumption of power.

7.9 Care, Continuum, Closet

Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) contested Lawrence Kohlberg's hierarchy of moral development by identifying an ethic of care—attentive to relationships, responsibility, and particular need—alongside the ethic of justice and rights. Lyn Mikel Brown and Gilligan's *Meeting at the Crossroads* (1992) documented the loss of voice girls undergo at adolescence, when the culture teaches them to silence what they know. Nel Noddings's *Caring* (1984) described care as engrossment in the other and the displacement of one's motivation toward the other's projects. J.D.'s ethic is justice abstracted to the point of annihilation: the school as a whole, judged and sentenced. Veronica's final ethic is care in Noddings's sense: one person, attended to, for one evening.

Adrienne Rich's "Compulsory Heterosexuality and Lesbian Existence" (1980) proposed a "lesbian continuum" encompassing the range of women's primary bonds with one another, including friendship and solidarity, and argued that compulsory heterosexuality disciplines those bonds. The final scene displaces the prom, heterosexuality's civic ritual, with an evening between two girls, and so locates the film's ethical future on Rich's continuum. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's *Between Men* (1985) theorized male homosocial desire, and *Epistemology of the Closet* (1990) the homosexual panic that polices it. Kurt and Ram's bond is homosocial in Sedgwick's exact sense, triangulated through a woman: after Veronica rebuffs them on a double date, the two boys spread a false sexual rumor about her, sealing their alliance with a shared boast about her body. That bond is policed by exactly the panic Sedgwick describes until their deaths are framed as a gay suicide pact, at which point the community converts panic into piety. J.D.'s forgery inverts the triangle: the charge the boys' boast had displaced onto a girl is made the official truth of their deaths. The satire is double-edged, and Chapter Nine returns to its residue.

The film also anticipates by several years the psychological literature on relational aggression—injury inflicted through the manipulation of relationships, reputation, and exclusion (Björkqvist, Lagerspetz, and Kaukiainen 1992; Crick and Grotpeter 1995)—and by more than a decade the popular "mean girl" discourse that followed (Wiseman 2002; Simmons 2002). A feminist caution is required here, and the film supplies it. "Mean girl" discourse risks pathologizing girls' aggression while obscuring the structures that produce it. *Heathers* refuses to let the clique be an origin. Behind the Heathers stand the fathers—the demolitionist, the football players' sentimental fathers, the priest, the principal—and the college men at Remington. There a college student presses Veronica for sex; her refusal, and her vomiting, provoke Chandler's threat of social destruction, which provokes the prank, which becomes the first murder. The causal chain of the film's first killing begins with an older man's sexual pressure on a girl. The clique is a relay of an order it did not found.

7.10 Ironies: Carter, Lorde, Haraway, hooks

Angela Carter's *The Sadeian Woman* (1979) read Sade's paired heroines—Justine, whose virtue is endlessly punished, and Juliette, whose vice is endlessly rewarded—as the twin impasses available to women under patriarchy. Martha is Justine; Chandler is Juliette. Veronica's trajectory is an attempt to escape the pair: she has been Juliette's servant and will not become Justine's executioner.

Audre Lorde's "The Master's Tools Will Never Dismantle the Master's House" (1979) poses the question the final scene cannot avoid. Veronica takes the scrunchie—the master's tool, the regalia of the sacrificial order—and announces a new regime. Can the master's tool dismantle the master's house? The film's answer is neither Lorde's no nor a naive yes. It is ironic, in the sense Donna Haraway gave irony in "A Manifesto for Cyborgs" (1985): an ironic political myth faithful to feminism, in which irony names contradictions that do not resolve into larger wholes, and the discipline of holding incompatible things together because both are necessary. Veronica seizes the tool and turns it at once to a use for which it was never made. The contradiction is not resolved; it is administered.

bell hooks, in *Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center* (1984) and later *The Will to Change* (2004), described patriarchal masculinity as a system that promises men selfhood through domination and teaches them to experience violence as proof of being. J.D. is that promise's terminal case: a boy who has learned from his father only that buildings come down, and who mistakes destruction for authorship. Valerie Solanas's *SCUM Manifesto* (1967), suspended between satire and program, haunts the film from the other side. In June 1968 Solanas shot Andy Warhol, nearly killing him, and wounded the critic Mario Amaya; the text's figurative violence acquired, in its author's act, a literal referent. The case names the possibility the film must confront: that feminist rage, once figured as violence, might replicate the order it opposes. Veronica's violence is real—she shoots J.D.—but it is directed at the single author of an imminent massacre, and it is followed not by a program but by an invitation.

7.11 Conclusion

The feminist reading discloses that the pharmacy's victims are disproportionately girls, that its administering hand is conscripted feminine labour, that its sovereignty is the apprenticeship of the gaze made absolute, and that its apocalypse is masculine. It also discloses that the film's exit lies on Rich's continuum, in Gilligan's care, and in Haraway's irony—and that Veronica's emergence as Beauvoir's free subject requires her to kill Woolf's phantoms, survive as Clover's Final Girl, wound her Gothic double as Judith wounds Holofernes, and refuse to be Justine or Juliette, Gretchen or the Eternal Feminine. What feminism alone does not supply in this film is the universal: the claim that an act between two girls holds beyond them. For that, the argument turns to humanism.



Chapter Eight

Humanism after the Explosion

Heathers *belongs to the anti-humanist moment of late-twentieth-century thought—its subjects are effects of a name, its interiorities are forged, its sacred is a fashion—and yet it ends with the minimal humanist act. This chapter places the film within the humanist and anti-humanist debates of its year, 1989, and identifies the humanism its ending requires.*

8.1 1989

The year of *Heathers* was a hinge in humanism's self-understanding. In the summer, Francis Fukuyama's "The End of History?" appeared in *The National Interest*, arguing, after Alexandre Kojève's Hegel, that liberal democracy might constitute the end point of humanity's ideological evolution. The same year saw Richard Rorty's *Contingency, Irony, and Solidarity* and Judith Shklar's "The Liberalism of Fear," both of which made the avoidance of cruelty the first principle of liberal life. In November the Berlin Wall fell. *Heathers*, released in the spring, is the year's darkest counter-text: a portrait of post-historical adolescence in which the struggle for recognition, deprived of historical stakes, persists as croquet, polls, and scrunchies—and in which the return of historical violence takes the form of a bomb in a boiler room.

8.2 Recognition at the End of History

Hegel's analysis of lordship and bondage in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807, ¶¶178–196) begins with a self-consciousness that desires recognition from another and enters a life-and-death struggle to obtain it. The one who risks life becomes lord; the one who fears death becomes bondsman. The victory is hollow: the lord is recognized by one he does not recognize, while the bondsman, through fear and labour, attains a self-consciousness the lord cannot. Kojève's lectures, published in 1947, made the desire for recognition the motor of history, and a famous note added to their second edition speculated on what remains after history ends: a return to animality, exemplified by the American way of life, or a pure snobbery, exemplified by the formalized arts of Japan, in which human beings negate the given through rituals emptied of historical content.

The Heathers are Kojève's post-historical snobs. Their rituals—croquet, the poll, the chromatic code, the exact grammar of exclusion—are recognition struggles conducted entirely in form, with no stakes beyond themselves. J.D.'s violence is the return of historical struggle into this post-history. His maxim that the extreme always makes an impression is a theory of recognition through the risk of death: Hegel's lord, armed. His failure is Hegelian in structure. He risks and loses his life, and he is recognized by no one but Veronica, who refuses him. The ending stages instead the alternative Axel Honneth (1992) derived from the young Hegel: recognition as reciprocal, distributed across love, rights, and social esteem. In a single scene Veronica offers all three in miniature—friendship to Martha (love), the jurisdiction of a sheriff (rights), and the public alliance of the most powerful girl with the most stigmatized (esteem).

8.3 Voluntary Servitude

Étienne de La Boétie's *Discourse on Voluntary Servitude* (c. 1553) asked why multitudes submit to a single tyrant who has no power except what they give him, and answered that servitude is voluntary, sustained by habit, by spectacle, and by a pyramid

of beneficiaries each of whom tyrannizes those beneath. Resolve to serve no more, La Boétie wrote, and you are free; the tyrant will fall like a colossus whose pedestal has been pulled away. The Heathers' power is La Boétie's tyranny precisely. It rests on nothing but the deference of the student body, mediated by a chain of lesser beneficiaries and sustained by spectacle. J.D.'s strategy is to destroy the tyrant's body; La Boétie's is to withdraw consent. The final scene enacts La Boétie's strategy. Veronica does not harm Duke; she takes the scrunchie, and the colossus simply stops standing.

8.4 Escape from Freedom

Erich Fromm's *Escape from Freedom* (1941) identified three mechanisms by which modern individuals flee the burden of freedom: authoritarianism, in its sadistic and masochistic forms; destructiveness, the drive to eliminate a world that threatens the isolated self; and automaton conformity, the dissolution of the self into the expectations of others. The film's distribution is again exact. Chandler is authoritarianism; J.D. is destructiveness; the student body, McNamara foremost, is automaton conformity. Fromm's *The Anatomy of Human Destructiveness* (1973) added the "necrophilous" character, drawn to death, decay, and the mechanical, and opposed it to biophilia, the love of life. J.D., the demolitionist's son, is Fromm's necrophile; Veronica's turn is biophilic. Fromm's positive freedom—the spontaneous activity of the integrated personality in love and productive work—is the humanist name for what the final scene begins.

8.5 Renaissance Humanism: Pico, Erasmus, Montaigne

Giovanni Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* (1486) has God address Adam as a creature without a fixed place, free to sink to the brutes or rise to the angels by his own choice. J.D. takes both paths at once: he aspires to heaven, the only place where social types get along, and descends to the brute. Veronica's self-fashioning through writing is Pico's freedom inflected by Stephen Greenblatt's caution (*Renaissance Self-Fashioning*, 1980) that self-fashioning always occurs in relation to an authority and an alien—for Veronica, the clique and J.D. Erasmus's *Praise of Folly* (1511) established irony as a humanist method: a speech that indicts the world by praising it. *Heathers* belongs to that tradition, alongside Swift's *A Modest Proposal* (1729), whose monstrous deadpan it reproduces in J.D.'s reasonable tone.

Montaigne supplies the tradition's ethical centre. "Of Cruelty" (II.11) names cruelty the extreme of all vices. "A Custom of the Island of Cea" (II.3) weighs the classical arguments for and against voluntary death with a sceptical equanimity that refuses both Stoic glorification and theological prohibition—the measured voice the film's death-chatter entirely lacks. "Of Friendship" (I.28) describes the bond with La Boétie, whose *Discourse* Montaigne preserved, as explicable only by the formula: because it was he,

because it was I. The friendship the film's ending proposes is far humbler than Montaigne's fusion of souls. It is humanist friendship reduced to its minimum, which is why it is plausible.

8.6 Enlightenment, Existentialism, and the Anti-Humanist Objection

Kant's formula of humanity in the *Groundwork* (1785)—act so as to treat humanity, in your own person and in every other, never merely as a means but always at the same time as an end—is violated by every act of the pharmacy. The forged notes treat the dead as means to the community's concord; J.D. treats the school as a means to his demonstration; the Heathers treat Martha as a means to their amusement. Veronica's invitation treats Martha as an end.

Sartre's "Existentialism Is a Humanism" (1946) held that existence precedes essence, that in choosing for myself I choose an image of humanity for all, and that flight from this responsibility is bad faith. Veronica's initial disavowal—her participation in staging Chandler's death as suicide rather than owning it as accident or crime—is bad faith in Sartre's sense, and her later conduct is the assumption of the responsibility she first evaded. Sartre's *No Exit* (1944), whose characters discover that hell is other people, describes the clique; the film's ending describes the exit.

Against these humanisms stands the anti-humanism that dominated theory in the decades before the film. Heidegger's "Letter on Humanism" (1947) rejected humanism as a metaphysics of the subject; Foucault's *The Order of Things* (1966) predicted the erasure of "man," a recent invention, like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea; Althusser declared Marx's mature work a theoretical anti-humanism. *Heathers* is fluent in anti-humanism. Its subjects are effects of a name; its interiorities are forged; its sacred is a fashion; its "man" is a face drawn in the sand of a lunchroom. The question is whether anything humanist survives this fluency. The film's answer is yes, but only at the scale of a dose.

8.7 Liberal Irony: Shklar and Rorty

Shklar's *Ordinary Vices* (1984) argued for "putting cruelty first," treating it as the worst of evils, and "The Liberalism of Fear" grounded liberalism not in a vision of the good but in the avoidance of the fear that cruelty inspires. Rorty borrowed Shklar's definition of the liberal as one who thinks cruelty the worst thing we do and joined it to the figure of the ironist, radically doubtful about her own "final vocabulary" yet committed to solidarity, which is created rather than discovered, through the imaginative capacity to see strangers as fellow sufferers. Rorty's chapter on Nabokov analyzed the cruelty of the aesthete, whose absorption in his own bliss renders him incurious about others' suffering. J.D. is that aesthete with explosives.

Veronica at the end is a liberal ironist in Rorty's sense: deadpan, unillusioned, without metaphysics, committed to relieving one person's humiliation. Her final line is ironic in tone and solidaristic in content. Yet Rortian irony is insufficient to the film, for a reason Chapter Nine develops. Rorty's ironist is private in her irony and public in her solidarity, whereas Veronica's irony and solidarity are administered in the same public act, from a position of power the sacrificial order created.

8.8 The Face and the Thou

Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) located the origin of ethics in the face of the other, which resists possession and whose first expression is the commandment: you shall not commit murder. Martin Buber's *I and Thou* (1923) distinguished the I–It relation, in which the other is an object of use or knowledge, from the I–Thou relation, in which the other is met as a whole presence. The Heathers' world is a world of It: names, colours, ranks, targets. "Dumptruck" is a defacement, the substitution of an object for a face; the forged notes are prosopopoeia, the conferral of false faces on the dead. The film's ethical turn is the passage from defacement to the face. Veronica, whose name is the *vera icon*, ends by receiving the face of the girl she once lured into humiliation. Levinas's commandment, unheard in Westerburg throughout, is answered in its last scene.

8.9 Natality and Power

Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) grounded political action in natality, the capacity to begin something new, and called it the miracle that saves the world from its normal ruin. *On Violence* (1970) distinguished power, which arises when people act in concert, from violence, which is instrumental and can destroy power but never create it. The distinction illuminates the film's three regimes. The Heathers' rule is a degenerate form of power, sustained by concerted deference. J.D.'s acts are pure violence, which destroys the Heathers' power and creates nothing but a cult of the dead. Veronica's final gesture is an act of natality, a beginning; but it follows violence (her shooting of J.D.) and takes the form of an office (sheriff), and so reopens the question Arendt's distinction was meant to close: whether a beginning can follow violence without being contaminated by it. That question is the subject of Chapter Nine.

8.10 The Imperfect Garden

Tzvetan Todorov's *Imperfect Garden* (1998) reconstructed the humanist tradition through three principles: the autonomy of the I, the finality of the you, and the universality of the they. The final scene satisfies each. Veronica acts autonomously, according to a law she gives herself; she addresses Martha as an end; and her announcement of a new sheriff claims validity for everyone. Todorov's title recalls the garden in which

Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) concludes, after every philosophy of optimism has been refuted by catastrophe, that we must cultivate our garden. *Heathers* opens in a garden, the croquet lawn of sovereign cruelty, and ends with an invitation to an evening in front of a television set, the suburban garden of a modest friendship. It is Candide's conclusion in Todorov's key: imperfect, cultivable, sufficient.

8.11 Conclusion

Heathers is an anti-humanist film that ends with a humanist act. It knows that subjects are made by names, interiorities by forgeries, and the sacred by fashion; it knows that the struggle for recognition has become a game of forms; it knows that the tyrant rests on voluntary servitude and the community on concealed murder. It nonetheless concludes with an act that treats one person as an end, meets one face, withdraws consent from one tyranny, and begins one friendship. What it lacks is a theory of how such an act can be valid when performed by a forger and accomplice to murder, from a throne she has just seized. That theory is antidotal humanism.



Chapter Nine

Antidotal Humanism

Antidotal humanism is the ethics the film's final scene enacts: a counter-gift of recognition, administered in a measured dose, from the position of sovereignty the sacrificial economy produced, by an agent who knows herself to be neither innocent nor curative. This chapter derives the theory from the philology of the gift, formalizes it in five propositions, develops its two central figures—the sheriff's paradox and the Veronican act—and tests it against five objections.

9.1 The Impasse of the Cure

The preceding chapters converge on a single impasse. Westerburg offers three remedies for its sacrificial disorder, and each is a poison. J.D.'s remedy is purgation: the elimination of the disorder by eliminating the school, a catharsis without remainder. Fleming's remedy is therapy: the management of the disorder by communal feeling, which ratifies the forgeries and propagates the contagion. The remedy the genre had made canonical, Hughes's reconciliation of types, is a sentimental communion induced by a drug and sealed by a letter; it dissolves difference rather than respecting it, and *Heathers* refuses it by name.

What the three share is the form of the *cure*. Each proposes to abolish the disorder at once and for everyone. The pharmacy teaches that cures of this form re-enter the economy they claim to end, since any cure administered to a whole community requires either a victim or a fiction of consent. The question the film bequeaths is therefore Stiegler's restatement of Camus's: what makes life worth living, once every remedy is known to be a poison? The film's answer begins with a philological fact.

9.2 Philology of the Counter-Gift

Four words govern the theory. *Pharmakon*, as Chapter Two showed, holds remedy and poison in one term. *Gift* means poison in German and a present in English; Marcel Mauss's short essay "Gift, gift" (1924) traced this doubleness to the archaic Germanic gift as a binding and dangerous prestation, often a drink, whose acceptance obligated and whose contents might kill. *Dosis*, the Greek source of "dose," means simply a giving: every dose is a gift, and every gift a dose. And *antidoton*, the source of "antidote," is formed from *anti* and *didonai*: a thing given against. The antidote is, etymologically, a counter-gift.

Mauss's *The Gift* (1925) showed that archaic exchange is governed by three obligations—to give, to receive, and to reciprocate—and that its agonistic extreme, the potlatch, converts giving into domination, and in its most spectacular forms into the destruction of wealth to humiliate rivals and seize rank. Georges Bataille generalized the potlatch into a theory of expenditure: societies must consume their surplus unproductively, in festival, sacrifice, and war ("The Notion of Expenditure," 1933; *The Accursed Share*, 1949).

Read through Mauss and Bataille, Westerburg is an economy of poisoned gifts. Chandler's invitation to the Remington party is a gift that obligates and humiliates. The forged love letter is a gift of hope to Martha that delivers public degradation. The cup Veronica hands Chandler is *Gift* in the German sense. J.D.'s love, offered as a theology, binds by complicity. Big Fun's song is a commodity-gift whose message is its own contradiction. And J.D.'s bomb is a potlatch: the destruction of the community's most

precious wealth, its children, as a claim to rank in the economy of recognition. The surplus of a prosperous suburb seeks its accursed share, and J.D. nominates the student body.

Veronica's final invitation is given *against* this economy, in four precise senses. It seeks no return, since Martha has nothing to reciprocate in the currency of status. It is not agonistic, since it raises the receiver rather than humiliating her. It destroys nothing. And it is addressed to the girl the first poisoned gift had targeted, so that it reverses a specific dose rather than proclaiming a general remedy. Derrida's *Given Time* (1991) argued that the pure gift is impossible, since any return—even the gift's recognition as a gift—annuls it by reinscribing it in exchange. The counter-gift does not aspire to that purity. Like every antidote, it is itself a *pharmakon*, defined not by its innocence but by the specific poison it neutralizes.

9.3 Paracelsus and Ethical Posology

The founding axiom of toxicology belongs to Paracelsus, whose third *Defensio* (1538) held that all things are poison and nothing is without poison; only the dose makes a thing not a poison. The later Latin formula, *sola dosis facit venenum*, compresses the principle. Its ethical analogue is older. Aristotle's doctrine of the mean (*Nicomachean Ethics* II.6, 1106a–b) is explicitly posological: the mean is relative to us rather than to the object, and Aristotle illustrates it with the quantity of food appropriate to the wrestler Milo as against a novice. Camus's *mesure* restated the doctrine for an age of absolute rebellions.

Ethical posology, as this dissertation proposes the term, is the discipline that asks not what the good is but how much of it a situation can bear, administered to whom, by whom, at what interval, and in what form. It presupposes Paracelsus's axiom: recognition, care, community, solidarity, and justice are all *pharmaka*, toxic in excess or in the wrong distribution. Table 2 sets out the doses *Heathers* administers.

Table 2. The doses *Heathers* administers

Remedy	Administered by	Dose	Effect
Pep-rally bombing and petition	J.D.	Lethal: the whole student body at once	Annihilation presented as collective consent
Forged suicide notes	Veronica and J.D.	Sacramental: one forged interiority per corpse	Concord founded on erased murder
Healing workshop and assemblies	Fleming and the administration	Iatrogenic: grief for everyone, about no one	Amplifies the contagion it treats
"Teenage Suicide (Don't Do It)"	Big Fun and the radio	Mass-market: repeated broadcast	Glamorizes the act it forbids

Remedy	Administered by	Dose	Effect
Reconciliation of types	The Hughes cycle	Sentimental overdose: every type is every type	Dissolves difference instead of respecting it
The prom	The school	Civic ritual of pairing and display	Recognition by spectacle
An evening of videos with Martha	Veronica	Micro-dose: two people, one night	Recognition without sacrifice

The scale is the argument. Every dose above the last is administered to a collective and claims to cure it. The last is administered to one person and claims nothing.

9.4 Five Propositions

The theory may now be stated formally.

1. **The Paracelsian axiom.** Every social good is a *pharmakon*; its toxicity is a function of dose and distribution. Community, recognition, and care are not exempt, and a theory of the good that ignores dosage is a theory of poisoning.

2. **The sacrificial theorem.** A community without transmitting authority medicates itself with victims. The *pharmakos* is the community's overdose of its own cohesion: the point at which the need for unanimity requires a body.

3. **The forgery theorem.** The sacrificial economy requires writing that converts murder into consent. Its founding documents are printed rather than witnessed, and their power lies in the erasure of the persecutors. Every community that remembers its victims as voluntary has forged a note.

4. **The antidote theorem.** The exit from the sacrificial economy cannot be a counter-cure, since every cure administered to the whole re-enters the economy. It can only be a counter-gift: a giving-against, administered in a measured dose to a singular other, that confers recognition on the expelled without sacralizing them.

5. **The sheriff's paradox.** The counter-gift can be administered only from the position the sacrificial economy has constituted as sovereign, because only that position can confer recognition that counts. Antidotal humanism is therefore ironic sovereignty: the assumption of the fetish of power in order to suspend its sacrificial use. It is never innocent, and so it is always provisional.

9.5 The Sheriff's Paradox

The fifth proposition requires development, because it is the film's boldest wager and its most vulnerable. Veronica's line—"there's a new sheriff in town"—is a formula of the Western, and Westerburg is, by name, a Western burg. The genre's most lucid meditation on the founding of civil order is John Ford's *The Man Who Shot Liberty Valance* (1962). Ransom Stoddard's career as a lawmaker rests on the legend that he killed the outlaw Valance; the killing was in fact done, from the shadows, by Tom Doniphon; and when the truth is finally told to a newspaper editor, the editor declines to print it: "When the legend becomes fact, print the legend." Ford's film is the American theory of concealed founding violence. Law begins with a killing it cannot acknowledge.

Veronica's sheriffdom has the same structure. The school will never learn who killed Chandler, Kurt, and Ram, or why J.D. died; the legends of suicide stand; and the authority Veronica assumes rests on knowledge she alone holds and on violence she partly committed. Max Weber's definition of the state as the human community that successfully claims the monopoly of the legitimate use of physical force within a given territory ("Politics as a Vocation," 1919) names the office she takes up, for the sheriff is that monopoly's local officer. Kantorowicz's body politic is thereby converted from a royal dignity into an office, from a grace into a duty.

Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) distinguished the violence that founds law from the violence that preserves it, and set against both a sphere of nonviolent agreement, of "pure means," whose subjective preconditions he named courtesy of heart, sympathy, peaceableness, and trust, and whose proper domain is language as the medium of understanding. Veronica's invitation belongs to that sphere: it is a conversation, not a decree. Yet it is issued by a sheriff, a figure of law-preserving violence. This is the paradox in its sharpest form: the pure means is proffered by the bearer of the means that are not pure.

The paradox can also be stated against Schmitt. For Schmitt the sovereign is he who decides on the exception. The antidotal sovereign is she who decides *against* the exception: who uses the power of designation, which in Westerburg has always meant the power to name a victim, to designate no victim, and to designate the one most marked for expulsion as a guest. Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) distinguished the figure who may be killed with impunity but not sacrificed from the sacrificial victim proper. Martha has occupied both positions: the epithet "Dumptruck" made her killable with impunity, and her attempt on her own life would, under the school's regime, have made her a sacred martyr. The counter-gift removes her from both. She is neither killable nor sacred. She is invited.

Plato's *Protagoras* (320c–322d) supplies the myth that grounds the paradox. Prometheus steals fire and technical skill for humankind, but technique alone does not allow human beings to live in cities; they destroy one another. Zeus therefore sends Hermes to distribute *aidōs* and *dikē*—reverence and justice—to all alike, since cities

could not exist if only a few possessed them. J.D., heir to a demolition firm, is technique without *aidōs* or *dikē*: Promethean fire without the political virtues. Veronica's final scene is the Protagorean supplement in miniature, *dikē* in the office of the sheriff and *aidōs* in the reverence of the invitation. The polis begins again at the scale of two.

9.6 The Veronican Act

In the devotional legend fixed in the Sixth Station of the Cross, a woman steps from the crowd on the road to execution and wipes the face of the condemned; the cloth retains his likeness, the *vera icon*. Girard's later work read the Passion narratives as the revelation of the scapegoat mechanism, told for the first time from the side of the innocent victim (*I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 1999). Within that revelation, Veronica's gesture is minimal and exact. She does not halt the execution, and she does not join the crowd. She performs an act of care toward the one the community has marked for expulsion, and the act preserves the victim's true face against the crowd's defacement.

The *Veronican act* may be defined accordingly: an act of care toward one whom the community has marked for expulsion, performed from within the community's space, that neither halts the sacrificial machinery by force nor participates in it, and that preserves the victim's true image against the forged images the community circulates. Veronica Sawyer's career is the passage from its inversion to its performance. She begins as the forger of false faces—the love letter that gives Martha a counterfeit suitor, the suicide notes that give the dead counterfeit souls—and ends by receiving a true face: Martha's, addressed by name, without epithet. De Man's prosopopoeia confers a voice on the dead and thereby defaces them; the Veronican act receives a face from the living and thereby restores it.

The onomastics are complete. Saint Veronica receives the face of a man on his way to death; Martha of Bethany is the sister of the man who returned from the tomb (John 11). Martha Dunnstock has returned from her own attempted death, and she is met, on her return, by the woman whose name is the true image. The film's first and last invitations can now be read as a single figure. The first, a forged love letter in a boy's hand, is a counterfeit *Thou*; the last, spoken in Veronica's own voice, is a true one. The first is *Gift*; the last is *antidoton*.

9.7 Purgatorial Ethics

Dante's *Commedia* (c. 1308–21) distributes the afterlife across three realms, but only one of them contains time. Hell is fixed and Paradise complete; Purgatory is the place of duration, labour, gradual purgation, and mutual intercession, where souls pray for one another as they climb toward a garden, the Earthly Paradise, at the mountain's

summit. Jacques Le Goff's *The Birth of Purgatory* (1981) showed that the doctrine's twelfth-century emergence amounted to the invention of a third place, an intermediate space and time between the absolutes.

Heathers is a purgatorial film. J.D.'s heaven, the only place where social types get along, is an infernal finality, since its achievement requires that everyone be dead. His boiler room is an Inferno, the furnace beneath the institution, and Veronica's descent into it is a katabasis; told afterward that she looks like hell, she answers that she has just come back. What she brings back is the purgatorial: catharsis distributed over time rather than concentrated in an instant. The cathartic economy traced in Chapter Two—from emetic to bulimia to poison to bomb—finds here its non-sacrificial form. Purgation becomes care, slow, repeated, and interpersonal, and the garden that opened the film as a croquet lawn of sovereign cruelty reappears, at the end, as the imperfect garden of a single shared evening.

9.8 The Feminist Corollary

Antidotal humanism is a feminist humanism in four respects. It begins from the gendered distribution of the pharmacy, in which girls are the privileged *pharmakoi* and feminine labour the conscripted delivery mechanism of masculine violence. It locates the counter-gift in a bond between girls, on Rich's continuum, in the register of Gilligan's care and Noddings's engrossment, and it inverts Jackson's sanctuary from a fortress against the town into an invitation extended into the town's lowest stratum. It refuses the Eternal Feminine: Veronica is not the redemptive object of a man's salvation but the subject who saves, and she saves another girl rather than the boy who ruined her. And it takes up the master's tool with Haraway's irony, free both of the illusion that the tool can simply be refused and of the opposite illusion that it is innocent.

The corollary also corrects humanism's characteristic failure. The universal claim —"a new sheriff in town"—is made from a girl's position, and the law it inaugurates is a law of hospitality toward another girl.

9.9 The Humanist Corollary

Antidotal humanism stands in a determinate relation to each humanism examined in Chapter Eight. From Pico it takes self-fashioning, but limits it: the self is fashioned not toward the angels but toward a dose. From Kant it takes the formula of humanity, but realizes it in a singular act whose universality is claimed rather than deduced, as in Todorov's triad. From Sartre and Beauvoir it takes the choice that wills the freedom of others; from Camus, the measure; from Shklar and Rorty, the priority of cruelty and the discipline of irony—though it joins irony and solidarity in a single public act, and admits its own complicity as Rorty's ironist need not. From the anti-humanists it accepts that the subject is an effect of the pharmacy, and from posthumanist thought

(Braidotti 2013) that the human is no fixed essence. What it retains is a practice. Humanism, on this account, is not a doctrine of human nature but a posology of human regard.

9.10 Objections and Limits

Five objections test the theory, and none is wholly answered.

The first is the *prosthesis objection*. Disability studies has shown how narratives lean on disabled characters as devices of resolution—what David Mitchell and Sharon Snyder called narrative prosthesis (2000)—and how disabled bodies become occasions for others' moral display (Garland-Thomson 1997). Martha, fat-shamed by her epithet and seated in a wheelchair in the final scene, risks functioning as the instrument of the able heroine's redemption. The reply is partial. The dose's smallness resists charity's redemptive grandeur: Veronica proposes not a rescue but an evening of watching videos, an activity between equals. Yet the film grants Martha almost no interiority, and the scene is framed around Veronica's gesture rather than Martha's response. Antidotal humanism must therefore include a posology of condescension: the recognition that care administered from above, or in excess, becomes another poison.

The second is the *sovereignty objection*, Lorde's. The new sheriff may be a new tyrant; the crown changes heads, and the hierarchy remains, now benevolent. The reply is a concession. Antidotal sovereignty is measured by what it refuses—the designation of victims—rather than by what it founds, and the film withholds the new regime from view. The theory is not revolutionary. It wagers that dosage can alter a system's toxicity without altering its structure, and the film does not verify the wager.

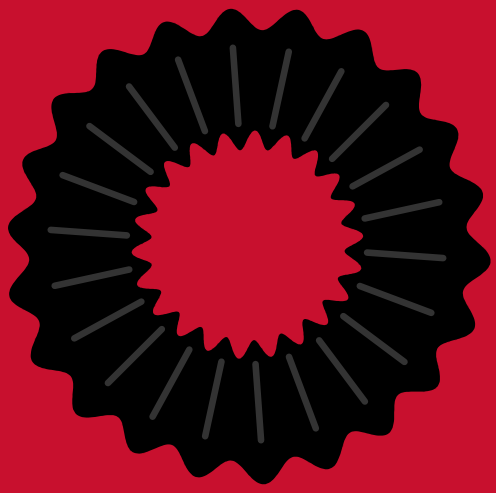
The third is the *particularity objection*. Westerburg is white, suburban, and affluent, and its pharmacy is a particular pharmacy; Richard Dyer's *White* (1997) showed how whiteness passes itself off as the unmarked universal. The film's world contains almost no racial difference and no economic precarity, and its universal must be tested elsewhere. The theory claims structural rather than empirical universality, and its doses are always local; but the concession is real.

The fourth is the *queer residue*. The film satirizes the community's posthumous piety toward Kurt and Ram, yet it also uses a fabricated gay suicide pact as a punchline, and its only gay men exist as forgeries of the dead. Lee Edelman's *No Future* (2004) argued that queerness is figured in the cultural imagination as the death drive set against reproductive futurity. The ending gestures beyond that opposition, displacing the prom, heterosexuality's ritual of futurity, with an evening between two girls; but the counter-gift arrives too late for those whose identity was only ever written for them. A posology of representation must ask whether the dose of a joke exceeds what its targets can bear.

The fifth is the *contagion objection*. Does the film, by rendering suicide and massacre in a seductive comic register, repeat the toxicity it critiques? Its post-Columbine rereading and the postponement of its television adaptation show it treated as a contagion. Media guidance on suicide, from the Centers for Disease Control's 1988 recommendations to the World Health Organization's resource for media professionals (2000), warns against glamorization and urges the presentation of alternatives. *Heathers* satirizes glamorization and ends with an alternative—care—rather than with a death. But no film controls its reception, and posology applies to spectatorship as much as to ethics. Antidotal humanism must accept that its own vehicles are *pharmaka*. That is not a refutation of the theory; it is the theory's first application.

9.11 Conclusion

Antidotal humanism may be stated in a sentence. When every remedy is a poison, the ethical act is not a cure but a counter-gift, given in a measured dose to a singular other whom the community has marked for expulsion, from a position of power the giver neither denies nor sanctifies. *Heathers* does not argue this theory. It performs it, in a scene of perhaps a minute, and then ends.



Conclusion

A New Sheriff in Town

Heathers *ends where its argument is complete: in a school corridor, with a soot-blackened girl, a confiscated scrunchie, and an invitation.*

The final sequence rehearses the dissertation's argument in under a minute. J.D. has detonated the bomb strapped to his own body outside the school, completing alone the Liebestod Veronica refused (Chapter Five). Veronica walks back inside, blackened by the blast; told by Heather Duke that she looks like hell, she answers that she has just come back, completing the katabasis (Chapter Nine). She takes the red scrunchie from Duke's head—the crown changes heads without an interregnum, as Kantorowicz's jurists required (Chapter Three)—and announces a new sheriff, converting a dignity into an office (Chapter Nine). Then she turns from the throne to the margin. Martha Dunnstock, in her wheelchair, is invited to spend prom night watching videos: the first invitation she has received since the forged love letter, and its exact reversal. No assembly convenes, no song plays, no adult appears. The therapeutic apparatus (Chapter Six) is simply absent, and the act that replaces it takes place on Rich's continuum (Chapter Seven), at the minimal scale of the humanist act (Chapter Eight), in the dose of the counter-gift (Chapter Nine).

In 1910 the Vienna Psychoanalytic Society held a discussion of suicide among secondary-school pupils, and Freud's brief remarks proposed a standard that reads, eight decades later, like a gloss on *Heathers*. A school, Freud said, should achieve more than not driving its pupils to suicide: it should give them a wish to live, and offer them support at the age when their development obliges them to loosen their ties to home and family (*Standard Edition* 11). Westerburg fails both halves of the standard. Its final scene performs the second half in the absence of every adult: one pupil gives another a reason to live through one evening. The film thereby relocates the school's educative function from the institution to the act of a single student, which is at once its indictment of the institution and its modest hope.

The invitation's content deserves the last analysis. Veronica does not propose a party, a cause, or a reconciliation. She proposes to watch videos. *Heathers* failed in cinemas in 1989 and survived on videocassette—rented, copied, and rewatched in bedrooms and basements by audiences that recognized themselves in its exclusions. Its last action prescribes that mode of reception: a small, domestic, repeatable viewing shared by two of the expelled. Benjamin argued that technical reproducibility detaches the work from the aura of its unique occasion and brings it into the situation of the beholder (1935–36). The pharmacological reading adds a clause. The videocassette, like every technical support of attention Stiegler analyzed, is a *pharmakon*: in Westerburg's media it carried the contagion, and in Veronica's living room it will carry care. The cult audience is a remnant in Agamben's sense (2000)—neither the whole nor a part, but what survives the operation that divided them—and each viewing is a measured dose. The film prescribed the conditions of its own survival, and in doing so administered itself as the antidote it describes.

The film's descendants confirm the theory by varying the dose. *Mean Girls* (2004), directed by Mark Waters, resolves the same problem by dispersal: Cady Heron, crowned at the spring dance, breaks the plastic tiara and distributes its pieces among

her classmates. The gesture is generous and therapeutic, and it abolishes sovereignty by pretending it can be shared without remainder. *Heathers* is more severe and more honest. The crown cannot simply be broken, because someone always holds the power of designation; the only question is what she does with it. The 2014 stage musical raised the dose of sentiment, recasting J.D. as a tragic lover and Veronica's arc as a redemption, and the 2018 television adaptation, postponed after the Parkland shooting, rediscovered the contagion problem as a scheduling crisis. The 1989 film remains the most exact dose: bitter enough to purge sentimentality, small enough not to kill.

The dissertation began with an arithmetic—teen angst with a body count—and ends with its final term. *Heathers* opens with three girls who share one name and closes with two girls who share one evening. Between the trinity and the pair lies the whole distance the argument has travelled: from sovereignty to office, from forgery to the true image, from sacrifice to care, from cure to dose. Westerburg's angst had a body count. Its antidote has a guest list.

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Keywords

Heathers (1989) | Daniel Waters | Michael Lehmann | teen film | black comedy | satire | pharmakon | pharmakos | Plato | Jacques Derrida | deconstruction | forgery | suicide note | prosopopoeia | René Girard | mimetic desire | scapegoat mechanism | political theology | Ernst Kantorowicz | sovereignty | Carl Schmitt | charismatic authority | Émile Durkheim | Werther effect | suicide contagion | suicidology | nihilism | Friedrich Nietzsche | Fyodor Dostoevsky | Albert Camus | Liebestod | aestheticization of politics | therapeutic culture | biopower | culture industry | feminist film theory | Final Girl | abjection | ethics of care | lesbian continuum | homosociality | relational aggression | humanism | anti-humanism | recognition | end of history | liberal irony | Emmanuel Levinas | natality | voluntary servitude | gift theory | Marcel Mauss | Paracelsus | antidotal humanism | ethical posology | Veronican act | sheriff's paradox | cult cinema | reception history